

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · August 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	79.8
#2	A+	Cincinnati	74.9
#3	A+	Hartford	73.7
#4	A+	Charlotte	71.4
#5	A+	Salt Lake City	70.1
#6	A+	Kansas City	69.0
#7	A	St. Louis	64.1

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	20.8
#49	C-	Grand Rapids	26.5
#48	C-	Chicago	28.6
#47	C-	Sacramento	29.5
#46	C-	Detroit	30.5
#45	C-	Richmond	30.7
#44	C	Indianapolis	34.2

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	11 cities
B+ / B / B-	21 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · August 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	79.8	3.1%	+3.4%	+2.1%	+0.4%	54 days
2	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	74.9	3.9%	+7.2%	+1.0%	+0.1%	40 days
3	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	73.7	2.7%	+5.2%	+1.9%	+2.8%	33 days
4	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	71.4	3.6%	+4.1%	+1.4%	+0.3%	57 days
5	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	70.1	3.6%	+4.6%	+3.2%	+1.0%	54 days
6	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	69.0	3.7%	+7.4%	+0.7%	+0.5%	47 days
7	St. Louis St. Louis	A	64.1	3.8%	+2.8%	+0.5%	+0.7%	44 days
8	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	63.2	3.3%	+4.7%	+1.6%	-0.1%	58 days
9	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	61.2	4.1%	+4.8%	+1.7%	+1.3%	67 days
10	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	A-	60.5	4.6%	+5.8%	+1.1%	+1.7%	74 days
11	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A-	59.1	4.1%	+1.5%	+0.7%	+2.0%	44 days
12	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B+	58.1	4.0%	+0.5%	+1.3%	-0.6%	40 days
13	Memphis Memphis	B+	57.1	4.8%	+6.6%	+0.1%	-1.4%	66 days
14	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	56.0	4.7%	+3.4%	+1.3%	+0.7%	54 days
15	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	54.9	4.0%	+4.9%	-0.1%	+1.2%	39 days
16	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B	54.8	5.2%	+4.0%	+1.4%	+0.2%	57 days
17	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.6	5.0%	+5.8%	+0.8%	-1.0%	44 days
18	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B	54.3	3.8%	+4.5%	-0.0%	+2.5%	50 days
19	Columbus Columbus	B	52.4	3.3%	+3.3%	+0.0%	-0.4%	40 days
20	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	51.7	4.7%	+5.3%	+0.6%	+0.5%	72 days
21	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	51.1	3.5%	+3.0%	-0.1%	+1.9%	56 days
22	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.4	3.4%	+0.1%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
23	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.9	4.5%	+1.9%	+1.0%	+1.2%	53 days
24	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	47.1	4.2%	+6.0%	+0.2%	-1.6%	39 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	46.4	4.2%	+4.9%	+0.4%	-0.0%	52 days
26	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	45.8	5.2%	+1.7%	+1.5%	+0.9%	50 days
27	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.8	3.9%	+1.9%	+0.3%	-2.1%	51 days
28	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	45.8	3.7%	+0.6%	+0.7%	-0.3%	58 days
29	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	45.2	5.0%	+3.5%	+1.8%	-2.2%	52 days
30	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	45.0	4.1%	+5.3%	-2.1%	-1.7%	39 days
31	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	44.5	4.4%	+6.7%	+0.5%	-1.3%	45 days
32	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	B-	44.3	3.8%	+1.5%	-0.1%	+1.7%	35 days
33	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	43.9	3.9%	+2.9%	+0.3%	+2.9%	46 days
34	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	43.3	4.0%	+5.5%	-0.7%	-1.1%	39 days
35	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	42.9	3.9%	+7.0%	+0.5%	-0.1%	85 days
36	Fresno Fresno	C+	42.9	7.7%	+5.1%	+2.5%	-1.7%	55 days
37	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	42.5	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	38 days
38	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	42.0	4.9%	+2.6%	+1.2%	-2.7%	67 days
39	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C+	39.2	5.3%	+6.0%	+0.8%	-1.9%	61 days
40	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C	37.0	4.8%	+0.4%	+0.4%	+0.8%	63 days
41	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	36.2	4.8%	+2.2%	+0.8%	+0.2%	65 days
42	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.7	5.0%	+5.3%	-1.4%	-0.8%	57 days
43	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	34.5	4.4%	-0.1%	+1.4%	-1.0%	38 days
44	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	34.2	3.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	+0.2%	47 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.7	3.8%	+2.5%	-0.8%	-0.8%	40 days
46	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	30.5	5.4%	+0.6%	+0.2%	+2.7%	39 days
47	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	29.5	4.8%	+1.1%	+0.3%	-1.4%	46 days
48	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	28.6	5.3%	+3.1%	+0.2%	-0.5%	35 days
49	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	26.5	4.2%	+1.8%	+0.5%	-8.8%	37 days
50	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	20.8	5.2%	+1.6%	-0.1%	+0.1%	43 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

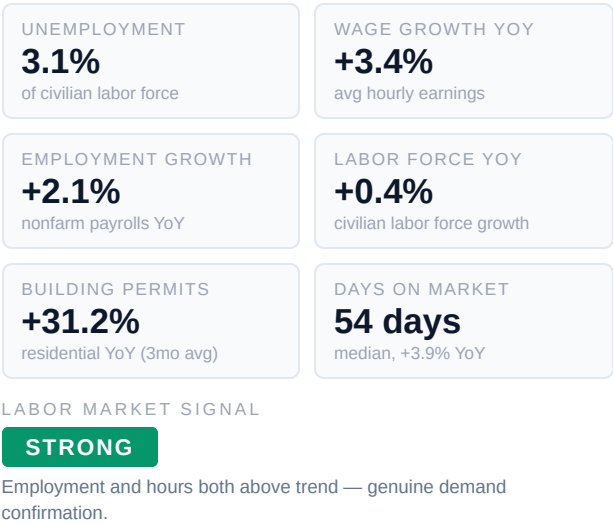
79.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 79.8th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.33, and its low unemployment rate of 3.10%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of a 2.07% employment growth rate and a 1.137% weekly hours deviation from trend also underscores the city's strong labor demand.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen a 2.07% employment growth rate and a 1.137% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting that businesses are actively seeking to hire and expand their operations. The labor demand composite score of 8.33 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, which is a top-tier percentile score of 94th, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available talent, and wage pressure is likely to be higher. As a result, companies looking to hire in this market may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.43%, which places it near the median at the 48th percentile. While this rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates moderate wage growth, which can lead to rising labor costs for employers. However, this also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, making the city an attractive location for businesses that value a skilled and relatively affluent workforce.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.64/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.77. Although this ratio is above average, the city's cost of living is still relatively affordable, particularly given the 2.2% year-over-year decline in PSF. This makes Raleigh-Cary an attractive location for talent, as businesses can offer competitive salaries without needing to provide excessive wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary has grown by 0.37% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 58th percentile. While this growth rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates that the labor force is expanding, albeit slowly. This modest growth suggests that

businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the overall labor pool is still increasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 31.25% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This significant growth in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate the city's growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is currently 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%. This places the city at the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively balanced market. While homes are still selling fairly quickly, the rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 98th. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that rely heavily on industrial or logistics workers.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for wage pressure and challenges in finding available talent in a tight labor market, which may require businesses to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top candidates.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

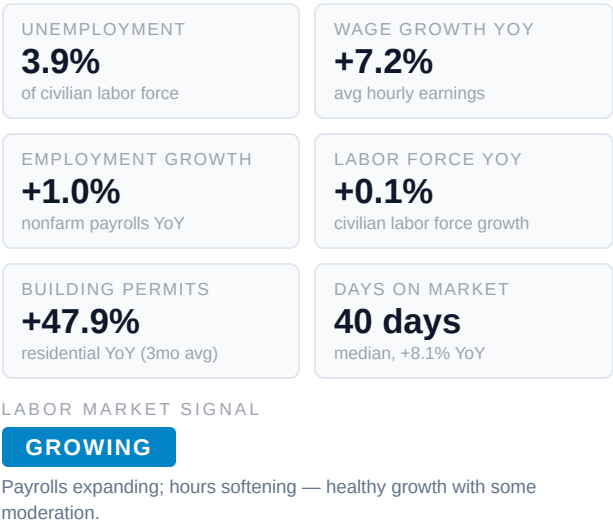
74.9th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 74.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and high wage growth of 7.22% year-over-year. These metrics signal a strong and competitive labor market.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is 0.97% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.372% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a near median labor demand, indicating that while jobs are being added, the hours worked are slightly below trend, suggesting some level of genuine demand expansion but not at an accelerated pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.90%, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure as a result. Companies looking to staff up in Cincinnati should be prepared to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is 7.22% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have increased purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these higher labor costs when considering operations in Cincinnati.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score that places it in the top tier at the 90th percentile, with a PSF of \$192/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.56/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. The city's affordability, combined with a slight decrease in PSF year-over-year, makes it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of 0.14% year-over-year, which is near the median. This slow expansion of the labor force supply implies that while there is some growth, it may not be enough to meet all hiring demands, potentially leading to a structural headwind for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

Cincinnati has seen a 47.86% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals developer confidence and improving affordability, which should support future workforce

accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

Homes in Cincinnati are currently sitting on the market for 40 days, with an 8.1% year-over-year increase. This top-tier percentile rank indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share places it near the median at the 44th percentile. This suggests a moderate depth of professional talent, making the city suited for a variety of businesses but perhaps not as ideal for those requiring a very deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance hubs.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique blend of low unemployment, high wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent and operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential structural headwind posed by the slow growth of the labor force, which may impact hiring capacity and require strategic workforce planning.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

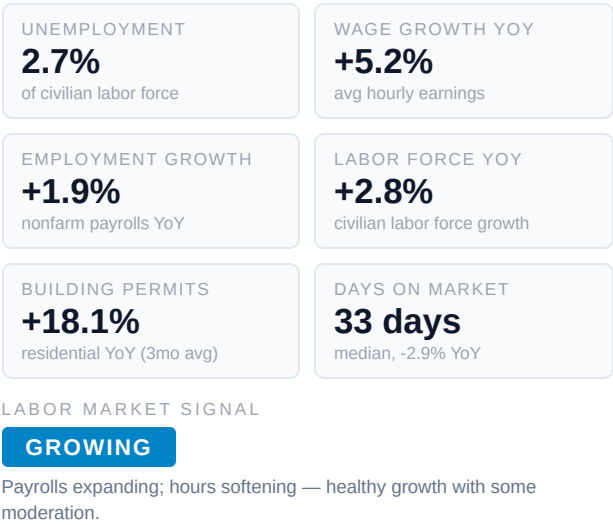
73.7th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 73.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor demand composite score of 6.61, which ranks in the 88th percentile. The combination of a high employment growth rate and low unemployment suggests a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.321% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average. The labor demand composite score of 6.61, ranking in the 88th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring and retaining top talent, as workers have ample job opportunities and can command higher wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.21%, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the benefits of a highly skilled and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living ratio of \$253/sqft to \$39.67/hr, with a percentile rank of 22, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is increasing at a rate of +4.1% year-over-year, which may further exacerbate affordability concerns. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply suggests that businesses have a large and growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is increasing at a rate of +18.05% year-over-year, ranking in the 78th percentile. This expansion of housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure and preparing for continued growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.9%. This rapid pace of home sales suggests a highly competitive and fast-paced housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share of 2.08, ranking in the 34th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep bench of specialized knowledge workers, such as tech or finance companies.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with a strong demand for workers and a rapidly expanding labor force supply. However, the city's high cost of living and extremely tight labor market may pose significant challenges for companies looking to hire and retain top talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

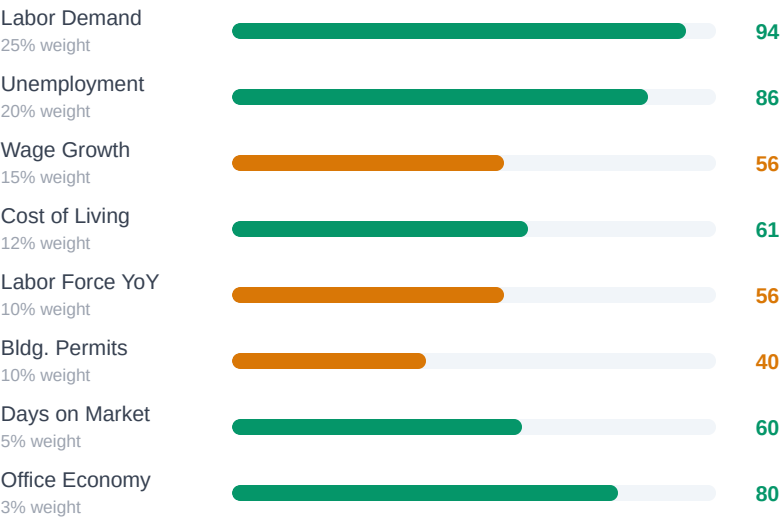
A+

EXCELLENT

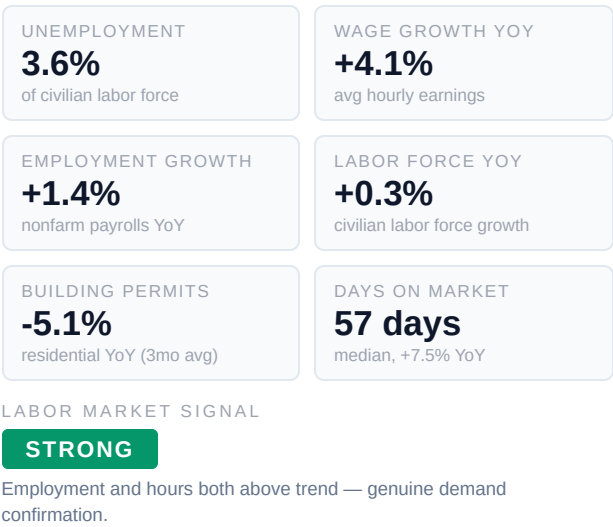
71.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 71.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, driven by employment growth of 1.36% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.141% above trend. The combination of these metrics signals genuine demand expansion, indicating a healthy and growing job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.36% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of 1.141% above trend suggest a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, signaling a robust economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, ranking in the 94th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% is relatively low, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.14% is moderate, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating that labor costs are rising, but not excessively so. This moderate wage growth suggests that employers may face increasing labor costs, while workers will see their purchasing power improve. However, the wage growth is not so high that it would significantly erode profit margins.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 61, driven by a PSF of \$220/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.80/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.82. This affordability makes the city attractive for talent, as workers can maintain a decent standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.33% year-over-year, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth suggests that hiring capacity is improving, but not rapidly, and businesses may still face some challenges in finding talent. However, the growing labor force does provide a positive outlook for future hiring needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.10%, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.5%, ranking in the 60th percentile. This suggests a relatively accessible market for relocating workers, as homes are not selling extremely quickly, providing a more competitive environment for buyers. However, the rising days on market does indicate a slight normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.36, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool of professional and office workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to reduced affordability and attractiveness for relocating workers, potentially impacting future hiring capacity and labor costs.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

70.1th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		96
25% weight		
Unemployment		80
20% weight		
Wage Growth		60
15% weight		
Cost of Living		53
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		72
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		16
10% weight		
Days on Market		62
5% weight		
Office Economy		96
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +3.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -21.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 54 days median, +3.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.1th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 96th percentile, and its strong office economy, also in the 96th percentile, with 4.32 out of 5 in terms of professional and office worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 3.20% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 3.20% employment growth rate and a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating efficient labor utilization. This suggests that the labor market is experiencing real growth rather than just absorbing existing workload. The labor demand composite score of 7.70 further reinforces this positive outlook.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.60%, placing it in the top tier with an 80th percentile rank. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire but not excessively so. For a business trying to hire here, this means they may face some competition for talent but can still find qualified candidates without extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +4.60%, ranking in the 60th percentile as above average. This moderate to fast wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are rising, which is good for worker purchasing power. However, it also suggests that businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent in this market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 53th, Salt Lake City-Murray is near the median in terms of affordability, where the price per square foot (\$265) compared to hourly earnings (\$39.49) gives a ratio of 6.71. This means the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. For talent attraction, this neutral position suggests that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums solely for the cost of living, but it does not provide a strong advantage either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of +0.96% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for hiring capacity. Businesses looking to expand or relocate can expect a gradually increasing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -21.89%, placing it in the bottom tier with a 16th percentile rank. This significant decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend signals a potential risk for businesses reliant on a readily available and affordable housing supply for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market stands at 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.9%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it provides them with more time to find suitable housing. However, this also suggests a normalization of the market rather than a rapid seller's market, which could impact housing affordability and availability.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite of 4.32 out of 5, ranking in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and talented pool of professional and office workers. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a moderate unemployment rate, and above-average wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies, especially those in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply due to the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

69.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		66
25% weight		
Unemployment		80
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		80
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		60
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		50
10% weight		
Days on Market		14
5% weight		
Office Economy		18
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -1.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, -2.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 69.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.38%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.70%, which together signal a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest that Kansas City is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's labor demand is characterized by an employment growth rate of 0.69% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.321% above its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked increasing above trend, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.59 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the above-average category.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City stands at 3.70%, which is in the top tier, ranking it at the 80th percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive environment.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.38%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid wage increases, placing it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, potentially boosting local consumer demand. Businesses should factor in these higher labor costs when considering Kansas City as a location.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$197/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$36.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.45, is considered above average in terms of affordability, ranking at the 80th percentile. This means that the city offers a relatively affordable environment for talent, potentially attracting workers without the need for significant wage premiums. The modest increase in PSF of 2.1% YoY, however, suggests that affordability might be slowly eroding.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.50% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's labor pool is increasing, providing a structural advantage for hiring and business expansion.

Companies looking to grow their workforce may find Kansas City an attractive location due to its expanding labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Kansas City is -1.26%, indicating a slight tightening in housing supply. This decrease in building permits may signal future affordability challenges and potential constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of this trend on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Kansas City are currently selling at a median of 47 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, placing the city in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, suggests a competitive housing market that may be challenging for relocating workers. The quick turnover in the housing market could make it difficult for new hires to find and secure housing, potentially impacting a company's ability to attract talent from outside the area.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is ranked at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong wage growth and low unemployment, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation issues due to the tightening housing supply, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain top talent over the long term.

St. Louis

St. Louis

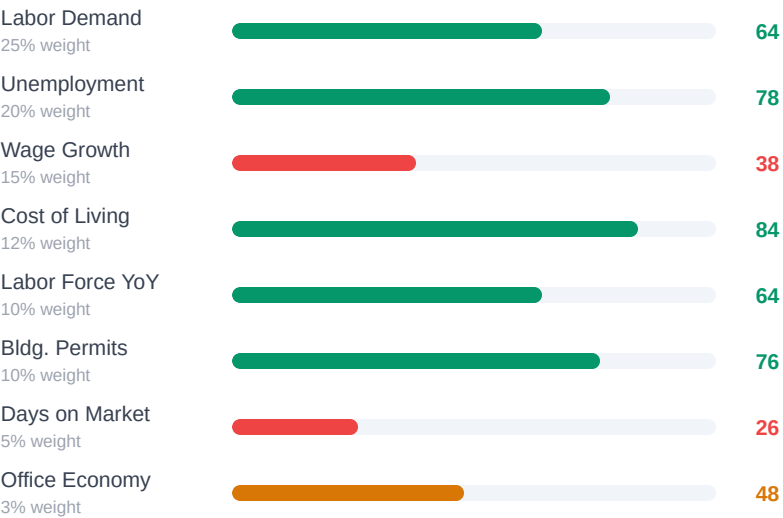
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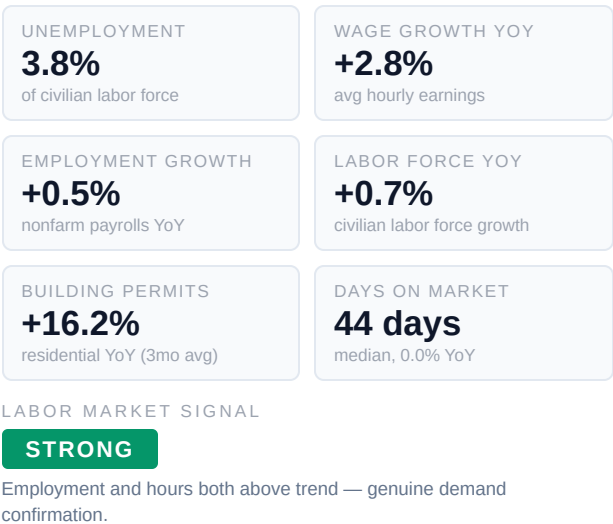
64.1th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 64.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.58, combining a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of \$164/sqft and hourly earnings of \$37.84, resulting in a ratio of 4.33, places it in the top tier for affordability, ranking in the 84th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.49% and weekly hours deviation of +0.598% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion in St. Louis, suggesting that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked. This combination signals a healthy labor market where businesses can find the talent they need. The labor demand composite score of 5.58 further reinforces this, placing the city above average in terms of labor demand.

Unemployment

St. Louis has an unemployment rate of 3.80%, which ranks in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with relatively low unemployment. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with a high level of employment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +2.84%, which ranks below average in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may help keep costs under control for businesses, it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing as rapidly as it could be.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.33, derived from a PSF of \$164/sqft and hourly earnings of \$37.84, St. Louis is highly affordable, ranking in the 84th percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -0.6% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find it easier to find the talent they need in St. Louis.

Building Permits

St. Louis has seen a +16.20% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which ranks in the 76th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses considering relocation, as it indicates that the city is likely to remain attractive to workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in St. Louis is 44 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the 26th percentile. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable year-over-year change indicates a balanced market that is not becoming significantly more competitive.

Office Economy

St. Louis has an office economy percentile rank of 48th, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a balanced mix of professional and non-professional roles, but may not be the best fit for those requiring a deep pool of specialized office talent, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, high affordability, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the relatively tight labor market, which may lead to challenges in hiring and upward pressure on wages.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

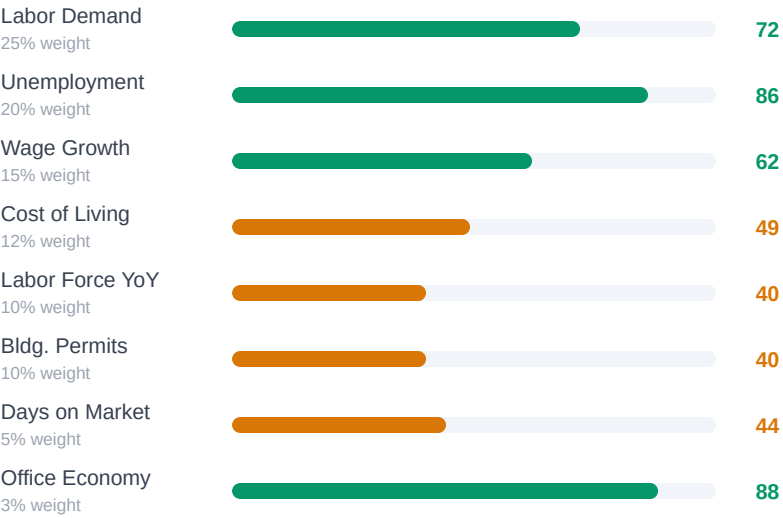
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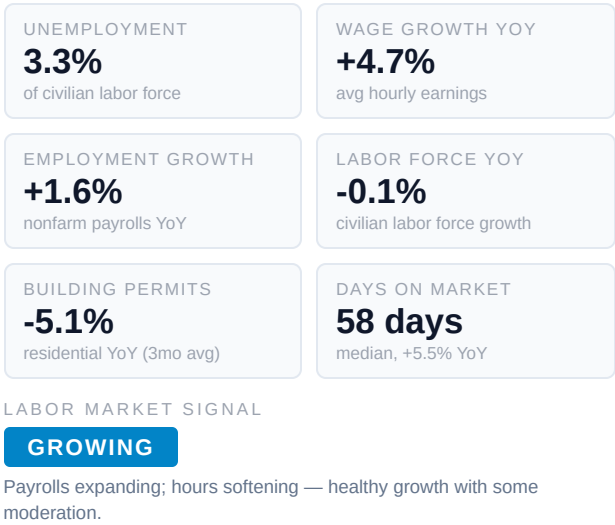
63.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 72nd percentile and 86th percentile respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.06 and unemployment rate of 3.30% signal a tight job market. These metrics suggest that Nashville is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with employment growth of 1.56% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.56% and weekly hours deviation of -0.424% indicate that Nashville is experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city's labor market is strong, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in slightly fewer hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.06 further supports this assessment, ranking in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.30% is relatively low, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.66% is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers also have increasing purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.35, based on \$260/sqft and \$35.38/hr, Nashville ranks in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The city's cost of living is relatively stable, with PSF falling by 0.8% year-over-year, making it neither particularly attractive nor deterrent for talent attraction without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by 0.14% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This suggests that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent. The negative labor force growth rate may also signal a structural headwind for the local economy.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.10%, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decline in building permits may lead to increased competition for available housing, driving up prices and rents.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.5%, ranking in the 44th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. For workers relocating to Nashville, this means that the market is becoming more accessible, with more time to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.86, ranking in the 88th percentile, Nashville has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to tap into a talented workforce. However, the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply pose significant risks, and decision-makers should carefully consider these constraints when evaluating Nashville as a potential business location.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

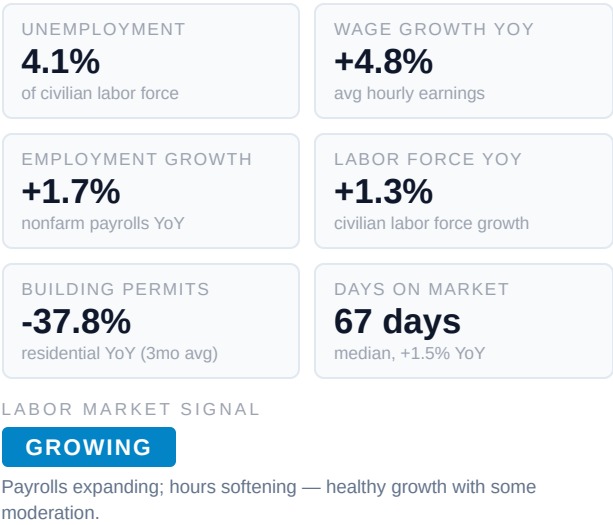
61.2th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 84th percentile ranking, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 96th percentile. The combination of a 1.70% employment growth rate and a cost of living ratio of \$234/sqft to \$37.54/hr, with PSF falling 8.6% YoY, sets Austin apart.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin is 1.70% YoY, paired with a weekly hours deviation of -0.262% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 6.42. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth, indicating a healthy labor market. The top-tier ranking of 84th percentile suggests a strong jobs market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin is 4.10%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication is that wage pressure might not be as high as in markets with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Austin experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.80%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This signifies moderately fast wage growth, implying rising labor costs for employers but increased purchasing power for workers. As wages grow, businesses may face higher labor costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, Austin is highly affordable relative to its peers, given its PSF of \$234/sqft falling 8.6% YoY relative to hourly earnings of \$37.54. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The falling PSF is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin is growing at a rate of 1.27% YoY, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates an expanding workforce supply, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity. A growing labor force can support business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.80%, ranking at the bottom tier of the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits is a concern for long-term workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin currently sit on the market for a median of 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.5%. This below-average ranking of 22nd percentile indicates a relatively fast market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising DOM could also signal a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Austin has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite ranking at the 94th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable workforce. Conversely, it might be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future housing supply constraints and affordability issues, potentially impacting workforce attraction and retention.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

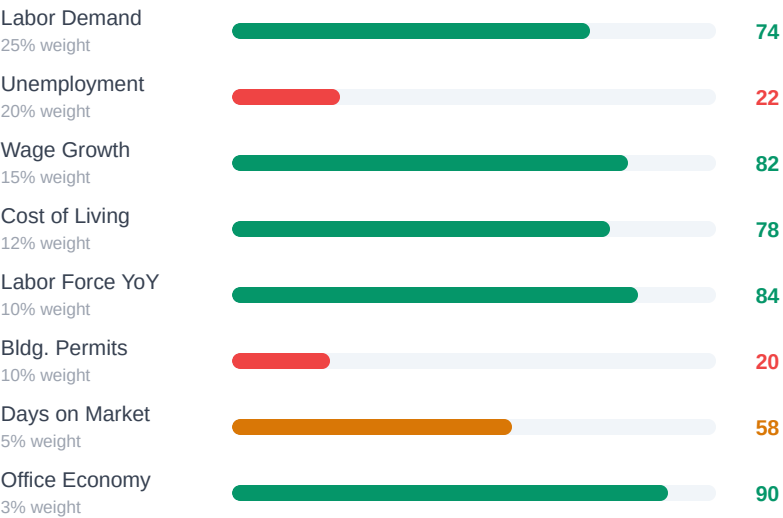
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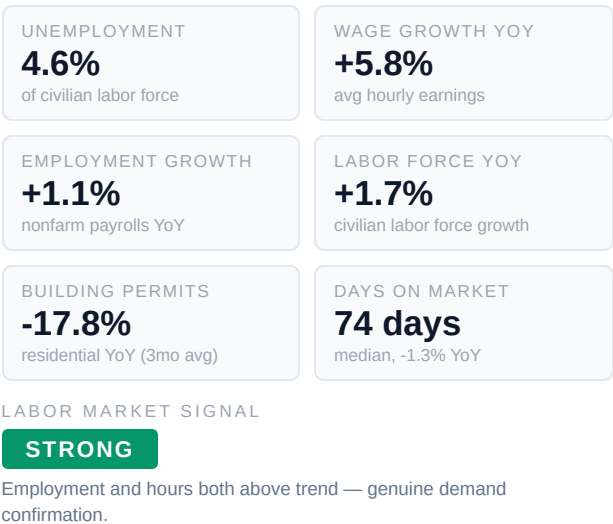
60.5th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 60.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, at 5.78% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a growing economy and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.11% year-over-year, combined with a 0.294% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a shift in hours worked.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.60%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. As a result, companies may experience upward pressure on labor costs.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area is 5.78% year-over-year, ranking in the 82nd percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses will need to budget for increasing labor costs.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score in the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$223/sqft to \$33.52/hr, or 6.65, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of 3.0%. This makes the city relatively affordable compared to its peers, which is a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 1.74% year-over-year, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff new positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 17.79% year-over-year, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.3%, ranking in the 58th percentile. This means that the market is relatively competitive, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city, as homes are selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

The office economy in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is deep, with a professional and office worker share ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and specialized workforce.

In conclusion, the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a growing economy with strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, and could require businesses to offer higher wages or other incentives to attract and retain talent.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

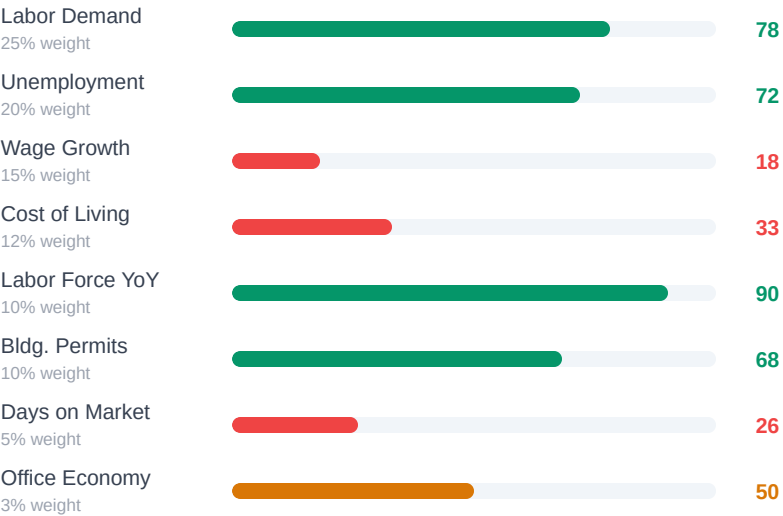
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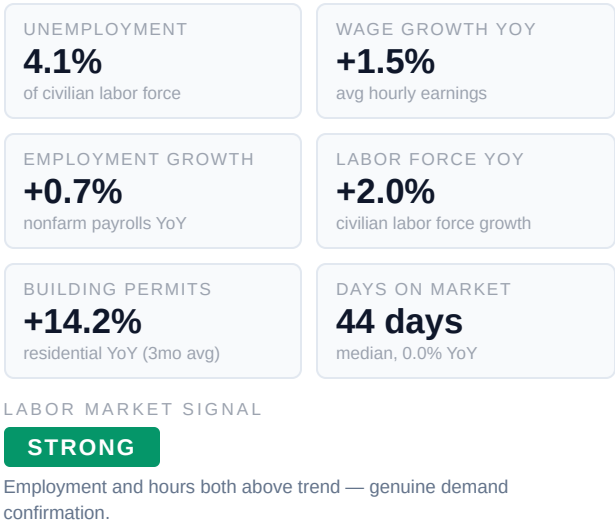
59.1th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 59.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its rapid labor force growth, at a rate of +2.00% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with expanding job opportunities and a growing workforce.

Labor Demand

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has seen employment growth of +0.74% year-over-year, combined with a +0.922% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington stands at 4.10%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the metro area has been +1.51%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating relatively stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have limited bargaining power. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively stable cost environment, but workers may not see significant increases in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$231/sqft to \$32.62/hr, ranking in the 33rd percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is relatively expensive compared to its peers. However, the fact that the PSF has remained steady year-over-year (+0.0% YoY) suggests some stability in affordability. This relatively high cost of living may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has grown at a rate of +2.00% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force implies that businesses will have a larger pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The metro area has seen a +14.19% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to see improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for its growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington currently sit on the market for a median of 44 days, with no year-over-year change (+0.0% YoY). This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 26th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially impacting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

With an office economy ranking in the 50th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for a variety of businesses, including those in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but it may not be as competitive as other cities with more specialized talent pools.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with expanding job opportunities and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and tight labor market may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain top talent without offering competitive salaries and benefits.

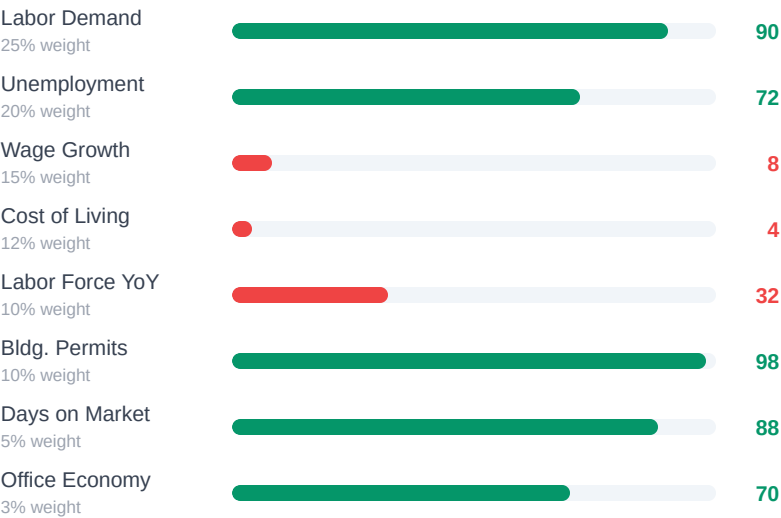
San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

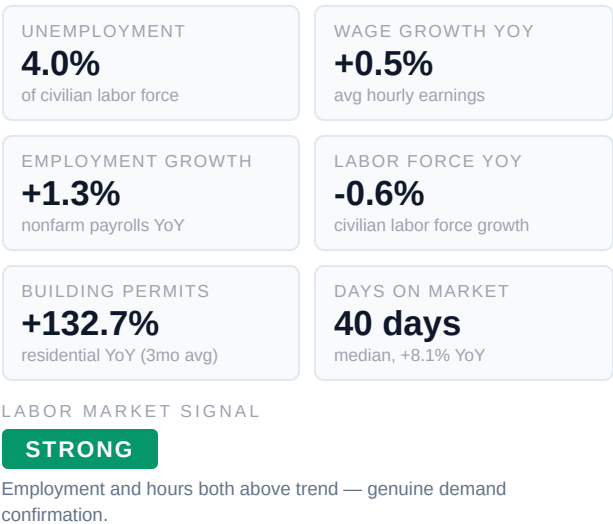
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.1th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 7.01, and its rapidly expanding housing supply, as evidenced by a 132.71% year-over-year increase in building permits. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and a proactive approach to addressing housing needs.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen employment growth of 1.34% year-over-year, coupled with a 0.839% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 90th for labor demand composite score further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara stands at 4.00%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests a market with less slack, where workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 0.51%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially less purchasing power. This could be a double-edged sword for businesses, offering a flat cost environment but also possibly affecting consumer demand.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 4th percentile, with a PSF of \$797/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$53.77, resulting in a ratio of 14.82. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 3.6% year-over-year is a key factor in its affordability score. However, the low percentile rank indicates that the city is actually quite expensive relative to peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area has contracted by 0.60% year-over-year, placing it below average at the 32nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies or consider relocation to areas with expanding labor forces.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is a significant 132.71% increase, ranking at the 98th percentile. This substantial rise in permits indicates that housing supply is rapidly expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 40 days, with an 8.1% year-over-year increase. This increase, coupled with the top-tier percentile rank of 88th, suggests a market that is slowing down, becoming more accessible for relocating workers. However, the absolute days on market is still relatively low, indicating a competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the metro area ranks at the 70th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that rely on a knowledgeable and specialized workforce, but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

In conclusion, San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara offers a business environment with strong labor demand and an expanding housing supply, which are significant advantages. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to consider is the tight labor market and the high cost of living, which could pose challenges in attracting and retaining talent without substantial wage premiums.

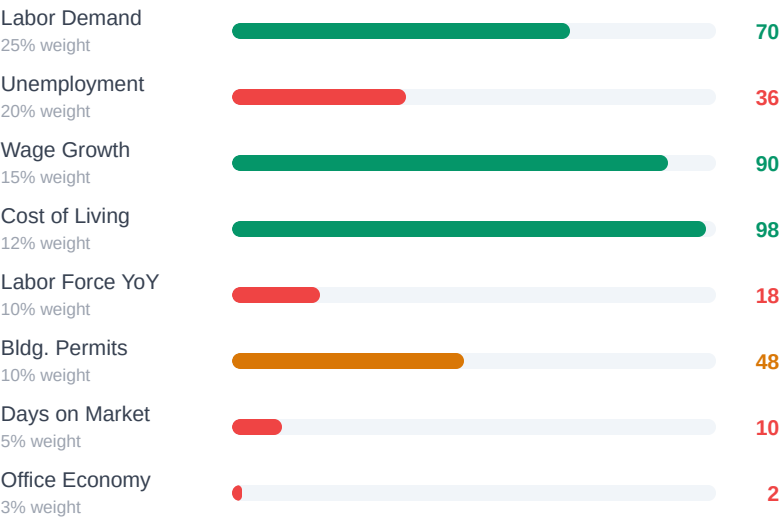
Memphis

Memphis

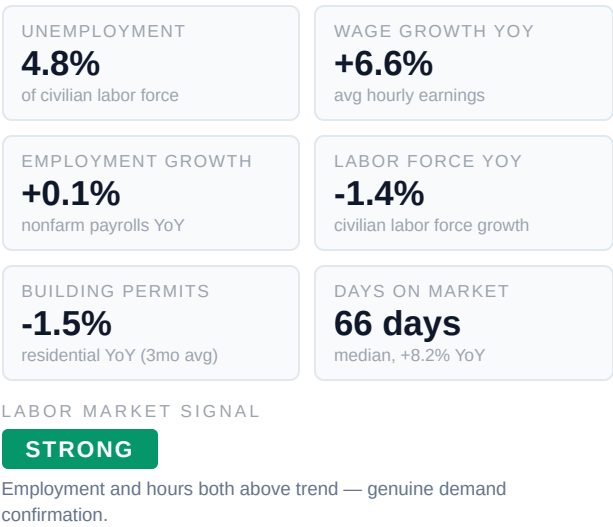
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.1th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.63%, and its high cost of living affordability, with a percentile rank of 98th. These metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of 0.06% and weekly hours 1.422% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in job creation, with workers putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.81 ranks in the 70th percentile, further supporting this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.80%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face less upward pressure on wages. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely low, suggesting that there is still a pool of available workers.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.63%, Memphis is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking in the 90th percentile. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The strong wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where workers have bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living percentile rank of 98th, making it one of the most affordable cities relative to its peers. The city's PSF of \$154/sqft is decreasing by 6.1% year-over-year, and the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings of \$32.74/hr is 4.70, indicating a very affordable housing market. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This could lead to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Memphis is decreasing by 1.49% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more difficult for workers to find housing. However, the decrease is not extremely sharp, so the situation is not yet critical.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 66 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.2%, ranking in the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slow market may also suggest some weakness in demand.

Office Economy

Memphis has a professional and office worker share of 0.38, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a competitive labor market with strong wage growth and attractive living costs, making it an appealing location for talent attraction. However, the city's shrinking labor force and slow housing market growth pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Memphis as a potential business location.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.0th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		86
Unemployment 20% weight		14
Wage Growth 15% weight		50
Cost of Living 12% weight		92
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		66
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		48
Office Economy 3% weight		92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +3.4%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +1.3%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.7%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -22.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +1.9% YoY 54 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 86th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.26% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.463% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.26% employment growth rate and a 0.463% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are increasing, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The top-tier ranking of the labor demand composite score further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.70%, which places it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other metros. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.44%, which is near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace, while also providing workers with some increase in purchasing power. This balance is likely to support a stable labor market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$201/sqft to \$38.32/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a year-over-year rate of 0.73%, which is above average at the 66th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -22.31%, which is in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This significant decrease in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This near-median ranking at the 48th percentile indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is strong, with a composite score ranking it at the 92nd percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a highly affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B

AVERAGE

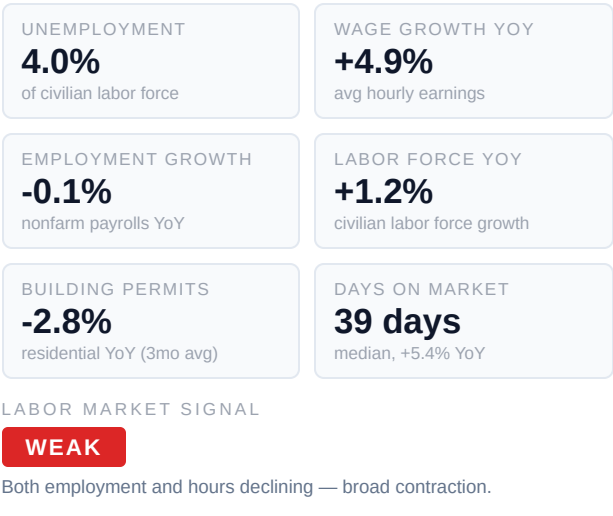
54.9th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average unemployment rate of 4.00% and strong wage growth of +4.94% year-over-year. The city's economic character is also defined by its cost of living, which is in the 86th percentile for affordability, with a price per square foot of \$216 and average hourly earnings of \$37.54, resulting in a ratio of 5.75. This affordability, combined with the low unemployment rate, suggests a competitive labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.10% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.673% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as both job growth and hours worked are below trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.16 is in the 22nd percentile, further emphasizing the below-average labor market conditions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.00%, which is in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means that it may be more challenging to find available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, the market is not extremely tight, suggesting that hiring is still feasible with competitive offers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +4.94%, which is in the 68th percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where businesses must offer attractive compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score in the 86th percentile, making it one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers, with a price per square foot of \$216 and average hourly earnings of \$37.54. This affordability advantage means that the city can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to minimize labor costs while still accessing a skilled workforce.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +1.23% year-over-year, which is in the 74th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that the city has a increasing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The positive labor force growth is a significant advantage for companies looking to grow their workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -2.81%, which is near the median, indicating a slight tightening in housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply may not be expanding fast enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. However, the decline is not sharp, suggesting that the impact may be manageable.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%, which is in the 86th percentile, indicating a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market means that there is more time to find a home, making the relocation process less competitive and more accessible. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing. The city's economy is more industrial or logistics-dominant, which can still support a range of business activities.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, relatively low unemployment, and strong wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs with access to a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average labor demand and tightening housing supply, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion and require careful planning to ensure adequate workforce accommodation.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

B

AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		92
Unemployment 20% weight		36
Wage Growth 15% weight		54
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		50
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		0
Days on Market 5% weight		56
Office Economy 3% weight		86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.4% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -39.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 57 days median, +5.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep professional talent pool. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.02, which combines a 1.42% employment growth rate and a 0.733% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, along with its top-tier office economy, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.42% and weekly hours deviation of 0.733% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.02 reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.20% is below average, ranking 36th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 3.95% is near the median, ranking 54th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers without breaking the bank for employers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Las Vegas, with a PSF of \$262/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.02, is near the median, ranking 51st percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The -2.2% year-over-year decrease in PSF also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking 50th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but only slightly, which may pose some challenges for hiring in the long term. However, the slow growth also suggests that the labor market is not overheating.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -38.98%, ranking at the bottom tier, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.6%, ranking near the median at 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible, for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The office economy in Las Vegas is deep, with a professional worker share of 3.86, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. This suggests that the city has a strong talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the significant decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting the city's other advantages.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

54.6th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		58
25% weight		
Unemployment		20
20% weight		
Wage Growth		84
15% weight		
Cost of Living		39
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		26
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		94
10% weight		
Days on Market		92
5% weight		
Office Economy		74
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +91.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 44 days median, +10.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 5.79% year-over-year and a significant increase in building permits of 91.03% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a growing economy and increasing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.81% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.048% from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.39. This combination suggests a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, it may not indicate a strong survivor squeeze or genuine demand expansion. The labor market is growing, but not at an accelerated pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, ranking in the 20th percentile, which means the market has more slack than most peers. This implies that businesses may find it easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets, but it also suggests weaker local consumer demand due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.79%, placing it in the top tier of the 84th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks in the 39th percentile, with a PSF of \$438/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$47.42, resulting in a ratio of 9.24. The PSF has decreased by 2.2% year-over-year, making the city less affordable than most of its peers. This suggests that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is below average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has contracted by 0.96% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could challenge businesses looking to expand their workforce in the area.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase in residential building permits of 91.03% year-over-year, signaling an expansion of future housing supply. This increase in building permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city is taking steps to address potential housing shortages and support its growing economy.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home and face less competition.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 74th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average labor force growth, which could pose challenges for hiring and workforce expansion in the long term.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

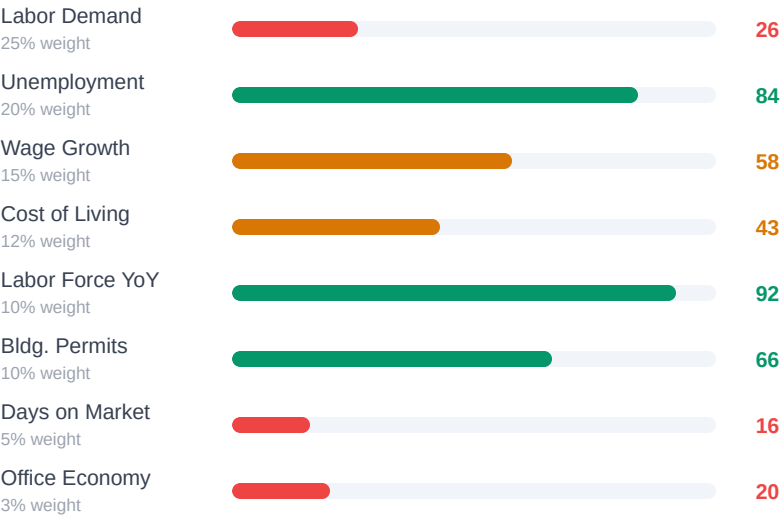
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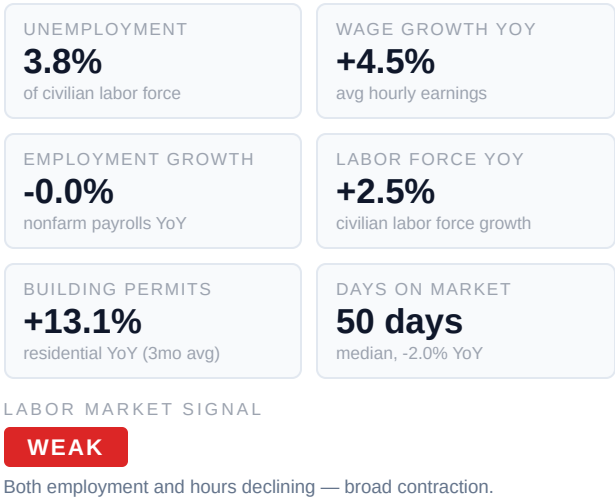
54.3th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B, ranking 54.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.80% and strong labor force growth of 2.55% year-over-year. These metrics define the city's current economic character, suggesting a tight labor market with expanding workforce supply. The labor demand composite score, however, is below average at 26th percentile.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.02% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.470% from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. This suggests that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate, and hours worked are below the trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.27 is below average, indicating a lack of strong job market momentum.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wage costs. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is 4.48% year-over-year, near the median at the 58th percentile, indicating moderate wage increases. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth rate may help attract and retain workers without overly inflating labor costs.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living ratio of \$174/sqft to \$33.21/hr, with a year-over-year increase of 1.8% in PSF, ranking near the median at the 43rd percentile. This indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to peers. The moderate cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but the city does not have a strong talent attraction advantage due to affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 2.55% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a growing pool of potential workers. The positive labor force growth rate is a significant advantage for businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by 13.14% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 66th percentile, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to see improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. The rising permits indicate developer confidence and a potential reduction in housing costs.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Pittsburgh is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This indicates a competitive market for relocating workers, with homes selling relatively quickly. The fast-paced market may make it challenging for workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate the competitive hiring environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average labor demand and relatively slow job market momentum, which may limit the city's long-term growth potential.

Columbus

Columbus

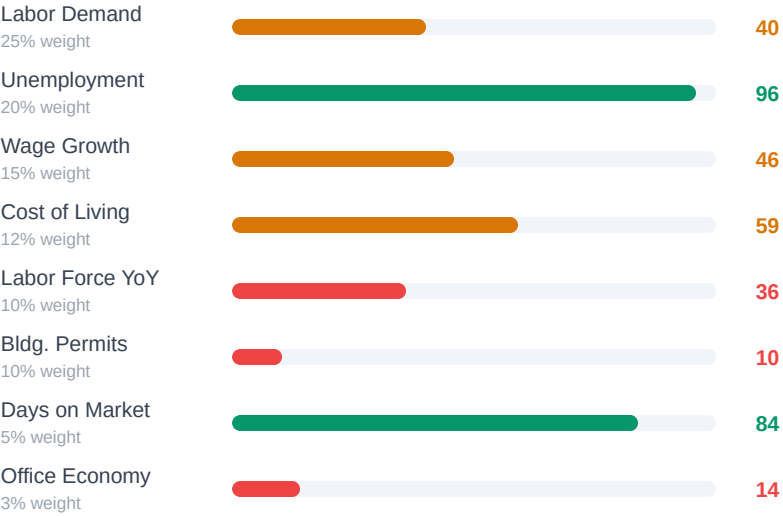
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AVERAGE

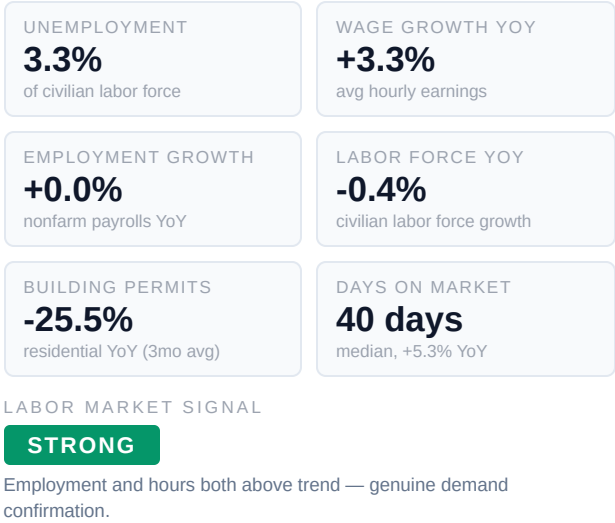
52.4th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 52.4th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.57. The city's economic character is also defined by its stagnant labor force growth and declining building permits, which may pose challenges for businesses looking to expand. Specifically, the combination of a low unemployment rate and near-median labor demand signals a tight labor market with moderate job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.02% year-over-year, with weekly hours deviating +0.246% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.57, ranking at the 40th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to higher wage pressure. With such a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +3.31%, ranking at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. This rate of growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain skilled workers.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score ranking at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$207/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of \$34.40, resulting in a ratio of 6.02. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable PSF growth rate of +0.0% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is contracting at a rate of -0.43% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified workers to fill open positions. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has declined by -25.53% year-over-year, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their workforce accommodation and retention strategies.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a decline in demand.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries, which typically require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. Instead, Columbus may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a relatively affordable location with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive option for companies looking to expand. However, the city's declining labor force growth and sharp decline in building permits pose significant risks to its long-term viability as a business location, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Columbus as a potential location.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

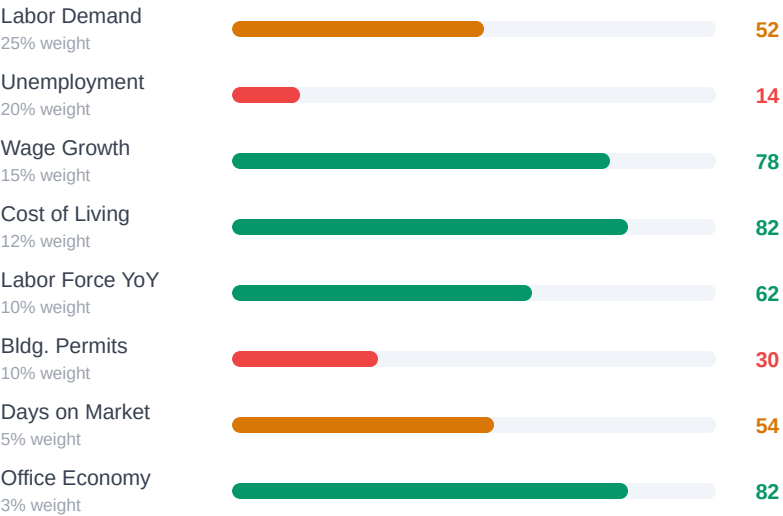
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AVERAGE

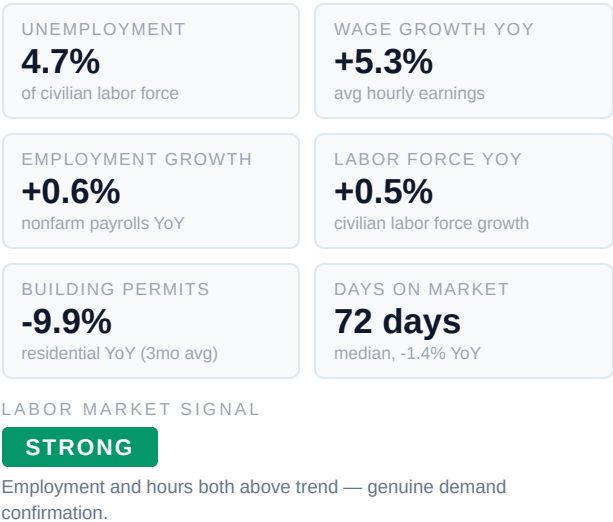
51.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of 5.33% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.12/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and attractive living conditions.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.56% year-over-year, combined with a 0.240% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing modest job growth, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting that employers are increasing their workforce and workload. The labor demand composite score of 5.32 places the city near the median, indicating a stable but not exceptional labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.33%, placing the city above average at the 78th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.12/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.8% in PSF, resulting in a top-tier affordability score at the 82nd percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, placing the city above average at the 62nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a favorable condition for

businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force can help mitigate potential labor shortages and support business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -9.95%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. The decrease in permits signals a potential risk for businesses relying on a steady supply of housing for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 72 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.4%. This relatively fast market, with homes selling quickly, may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the slight decrease in days on market could indicate a normalization of the housing market, making it more accessible for workers to find homes.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking at the 82nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for talent and business expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability challenges and impact workforce accommodation.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

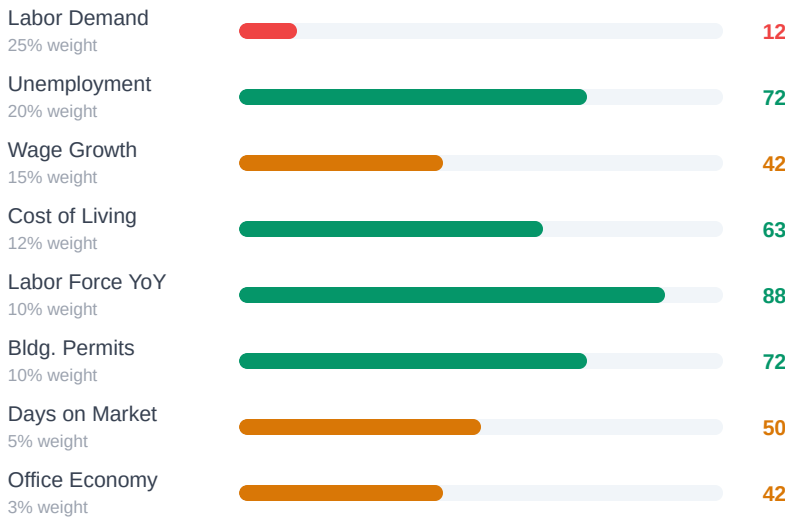
B

AVERAGE

51.1th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+15.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

56 days

median, +3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor force growth and cost of living. The city's labor force is growing at a rate of 1.93% YoY, and its cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.32. These two metrics define the city's current economic character, with a growing workforce and manageable living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.11% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating 0.454% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.69 is in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.50%, which is relatively low, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in Atlanta may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Atlanta is 2.99% YoY, which is near the median, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the pace of wage growth is not exceptionally strong.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks at the 63rd percentile, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio is 5.32, with PSF at \$197/sqft, and this affordability is a talent attraction advantage, as workers can be drawn to the city without requiring significant wage premiums. This is a positive factor for businesses considering relocation.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of 1.93% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 88th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The increasing workforce can support the needs of companies looking to staff up.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Atlanta is increasing by 15.16% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is preparing for its growing population. The increase in permits should help to maintain affordability and support workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Atlanta is 56 days, with a YoY increase of 3.7%. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor excessively slow. For workers relocating to Atlanta, the market is accessible, but not overly favorable to buyers, suggesting a relatively normal pace of home sales.

Office Economy

Atlanta has an office economy score that ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance firms.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to upward wage pressure and challenges in finding available talent.

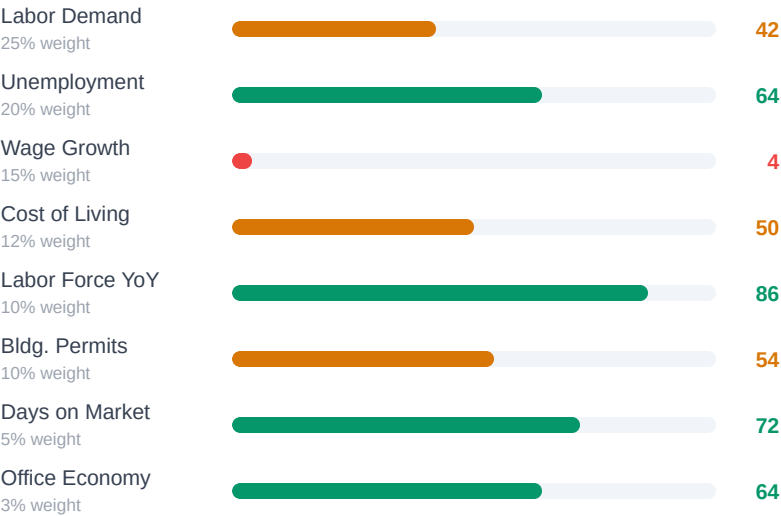
Cleveland

Cleveland

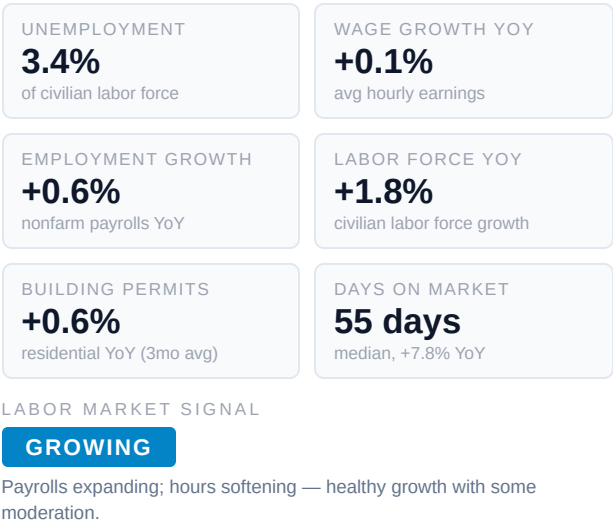
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.4th percentile
Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.66 and its bottom-tier wage growth of +0.10% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with labor demand neither strongly expanding nor contracting, and wage growth that is notably stagnant.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.438% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction, but rather a period of stabilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking it at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. However, the market is not extremely tight, suggesting that hiring is still feasible with some effort.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is +0.10% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising significantly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing. This could impact the attractiveness of the city for businesses relying on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of \$143/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.00/hr, results in a ratio of 4.21, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The modest affordability may not provide a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which could facilitate hiring for businesses.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cleveland are increasing by +0.56% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This modest growth in permits indicates that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing

workforce over time.

Days on Market

Homes in Cleveland are currently sitting on the market for 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%, ranking it above average at the 72nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, which could be more accessible for relocating workers, as they have more time to find a home without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of professional and office workers is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, the city may be less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a mixed economic environment with a growing labor force and modestly expanding housing supply, but it is constrained by stagnant wage growth and a relatively tight labor market. The single biggest risk for a business considering Cleveland is the potential for upward wage pressure due to the tight labor market, which could increase labor costs over time.

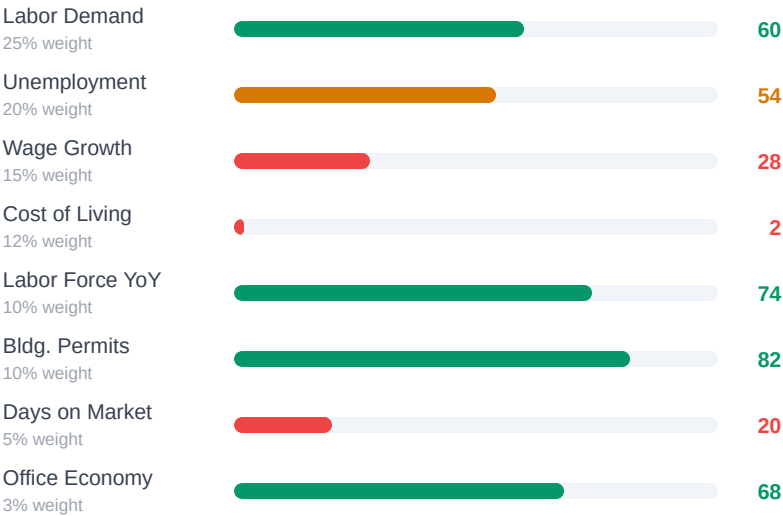
New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.9th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average wage growth of +1.95% year-over-year and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of \$522/sqft to \$40.39/hr, ranking it in the 2nd percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.42, which is above average, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is +0.96% year-over-year, and the weekly hours deviation from its own trend is -0.228%, indicating a moderate expansion of genuine demand. This combination signals that the city is experiencing job growth, albeit with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting that the demand expansion is not overly strained. The above-average labor demand composite score of 5.42 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.50%, ranking it near the median at the 54th percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may not face extreme competition for talent, it still needs to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract the right candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is +1.95%, which is below average, ranking it at the 28th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. For businesses, this could mean a relatively stable labor cost environment, but it may also indicate weaker consumer demand due to stagnant wages.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$522/sqft to \$40.39/hr and a percentile rank of 2, this city is extremely expensive relative to its peers. The fact that the PSF is increasing by +2.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that attracting talent without offering significant wage premiums will be challenging, as the high cost of living could deter potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of +1.23% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a larger pool of

potential candidates. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, so businesses should still be mindful of their hiring strategies.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +22.60%, ranking this metro area in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.9%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is competitive, and they may face challenges in finding and securing a home quickly.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.08, ranking it above average at the 68th percentile, this city has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different skill sets.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, which could support workforce growth and attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which necessitates significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting business competitiveness.

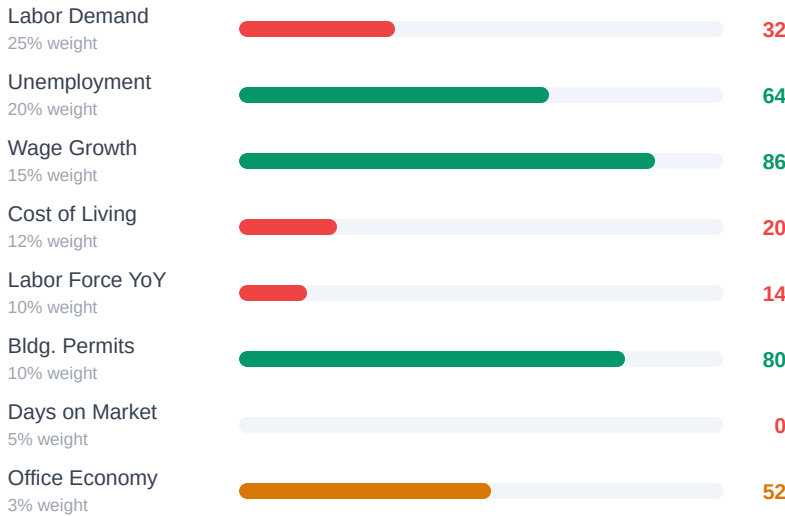
San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.1th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days
median, -13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.99%, and its low labor force growth, with a year-over-year decline of -1.59%. These metrics signal a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.22% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as the small employment growth is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.20%, ranking it at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure, as the low unemployment rate gives workers more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.99%, ranking it at the 86th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increases worker purchasing power, making the area attractive for workers but potentially costly for businesses.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score ranking it at the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$629/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$49.82, resulting in a ratio of 12.63. The fact that PSF is falling -4.8% year-over-year is a key driver of the relatively low affordability score, indicating that the city is expensive relative to peers, which may require wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is declining -1.59% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the shrinking labor pool limits the availability of workers for businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +19.88%, ranking it at the 80th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.3%, ranking it at the 0th percentile. This extremely competitive market means that homes are selling very quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as the market favors sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a professional and office worker share ranking it at the 52nd percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors but may not offer the same advantages for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong, talented workforce with high wage growth, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market, high cost of living, and extremely competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the low labor force growth, which may limit the availability of workers and drive up labor costs, making it essential to factor in strategies for attracting and retaining talent in this competitive environment.

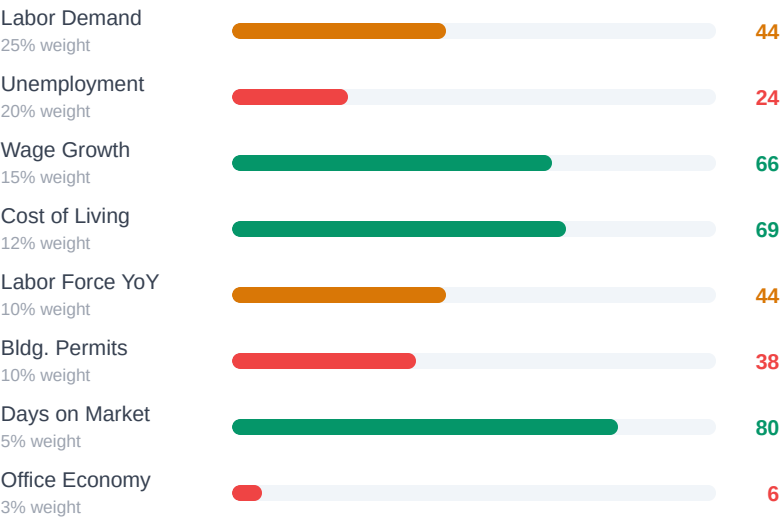
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

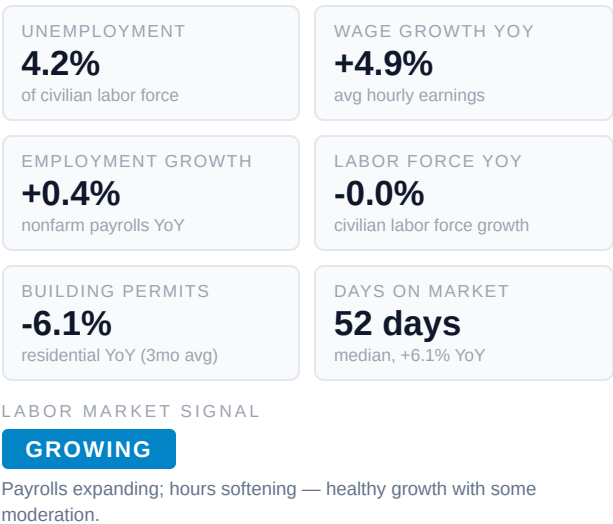
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.4th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average wage growth of 4.86% year-over-year and its below-average unemployment rate of 4.20%, which signals a relatively tight labor market. These metrics suggest that while the city has a strong workforce, hiring may be challenging due to low unemployment.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is 0.43% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.070% from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a near-median labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing significant job expansion or contraction. The labor demand composite score of 4.83 also falls near the median, suggesting a stable but not particularly robust job market.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 4.20% is below average, ranking it in the 24th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. As a result, companies may experience upward pressure on wages in this market.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City's year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.86% is above average, ranking it in the 66th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also expect a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$172/sqft to \$33.54/hr, Oklahoma City ranks in the 69th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable year-over-year change in PSF of 0.0% also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate is -0.04% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the workforce supply. This near-median growth rate suggests that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may need to compete more intensely for available talent.

Building Permits

Oklahoma City's year-over-year change in building permits is -6.14%, ranking it in the 38th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Oklahoma City is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.1%, ranking it in the 80th percentile. This slower market means that homes are taking longer to sell, making it a more accessible market for relocating workers. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a significant decrease in demand.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is better suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a relatively affordable location with a strong workforce, but its tight labor market and rising wages may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth and tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased competition for talent and decreased affordability in the future.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		68
Unemployment 20% weight		6
Wage Growth 15% weight		22
Cost of Living 12% weight		94
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		70
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		26
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -14.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score at the 68th percentile, and its very affordable cost of living, ranked at the 94th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.46% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.639% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.46% and the -0.639% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs at a moderate pace without overburdening the existing workforce. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 further supports this interpretation, ranking at the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.20% is relatively high, ranking at the 6th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This implies that businesses may find it easier to hire in this city compared to others with tighter labor markets. However, the higher unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.71% is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising too quickly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing rapidly. The slow wage growth may lead to a relatively flat cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$171/sqft to \$36.90/hr, and a -2.3% year-over-year change in PSF, this city is very affordable, ranking at the 94th percentile. This high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a good standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a 0.88% year-over-year rate, ranking at the 70th percentile, which indicates that the workforce supply is expanding. This positive growth rate implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -14.66%, ranking at the 24th percentile, which signals that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a 0.0% year-over-year change, ranking at the 26th percentile. This means that the market is relatively competitive, and homes are selling quickly. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.34, ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may not be as suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of moderate labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a growing labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

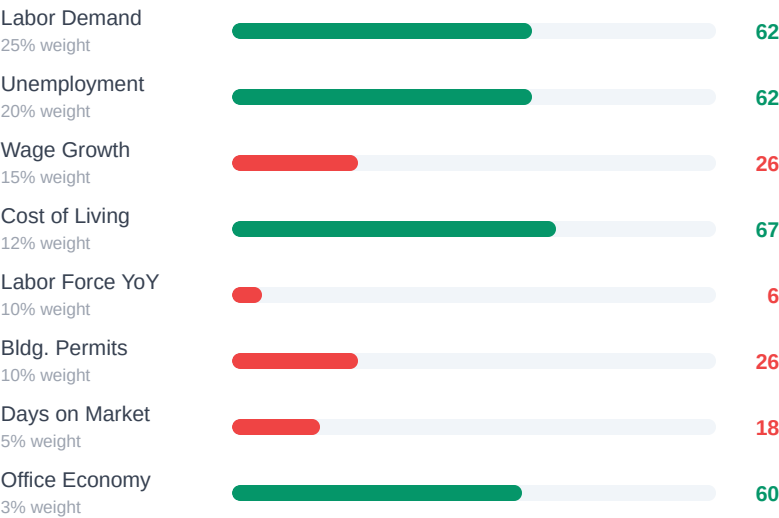
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

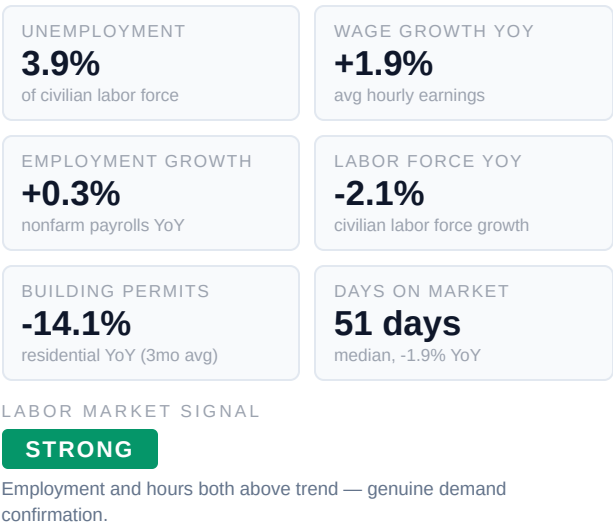
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.42, and its below-average wage growth, at +1.94% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics provide a nuanced view of the city's job market, with the former indicating genuine demand expansion and the latter suggesting moderate labor cost increases.

Labor Demand

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.31% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.687% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in job creation, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting that employers are increasing production to meet growing demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.42 ranks in the 62nd percentile, further supporting the notion of genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.90%, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This suggests that there is some slack in the market, but it may still be challenging for businesses to find qualified candidates, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. With an unemployment rate below the national average, businesses may face competition for top talent, making it essential to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.94%, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate labor cost increases. This rate of wage growth suggests that employers may face rising labor costs, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. As a result, workers in the area may experience modest increases in purchasing power, but businesses may not face extreme pressure to raise wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking in the 67th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$284/sqft to \$42.59/hr, equivalent to 6.67. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF value (-3.1% year-over-year) contributing to its high affordability score. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has contracted by -2.15% year-over-year, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to hire, as it may lead to a structural headwind in finding qualified candidates. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs or consider relocating to areas with more abundant labor supplies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by -14.11% year-over-year, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially making it more difficult for businesses to attract and retain talent. As a result, companies may need to consider the potential long-term implications of a tightening housing market on their workforce accommodation and recruitment strategies.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is currently 51 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.9%, ranking in the 18th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find suitable housing. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or flexible housing options to attract top talent.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has an office economy score ranking in the 60th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and talent acquisition in the long term.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		54
25% weight		
Unemployment		42
20% weight		
Wage Growth		10
15% weight		
Cost of Living		57
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		38
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		84
10% weight		
Days on Market		40
5% weight		
Office Economy		46
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +31.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, +1.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and low wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.35, combining a +0.65% employment growth rate and a +0.140% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests a genuine but modest demand expansion. The low wage growth rate of +0.57% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, is a key factor defining the city's economic character.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.65% and weekly hours deviation of +0.140% from its own trend indicate a moderate expansion of labor demand, signaling genuine demand for workers rather than a survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the recent average, a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the near-median ranking of this metric suggests that labor demand is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.70% ranks in the near-median 42nd percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire workers, there is still some competition for talent. For businesses trying to hire in Birmingham, this means they may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top candidates.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.57%, Birmingham ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a relatively flat cost environment, but it may also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and an earnings ratio of 4.88, ranks in the near-median 57th percentile, suggesting that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.2% year-over-year further supports this affordability. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.28% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in the labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained in the future, making it potentially more challenging for businesses to

find the workers they need.

Building Permits

Birmingham is experiencing a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of +31.24%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making the city more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Birmingham is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This near-median ranking suggests a relatively balanced housing market that is not extremely competitive or accessible. For workers relocating to the city, this means they may have a moderate amount of time to find a home without feeling undue pressure.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the near-median 46th percentile, Birmingham has a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries requiring a large pool of specialized or industrial workers.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate labor market, but its slow wage growth and contracting labor force supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining top talent due to the stagnant wage growth, which could limit the city's appeal to workers and businesses alike.

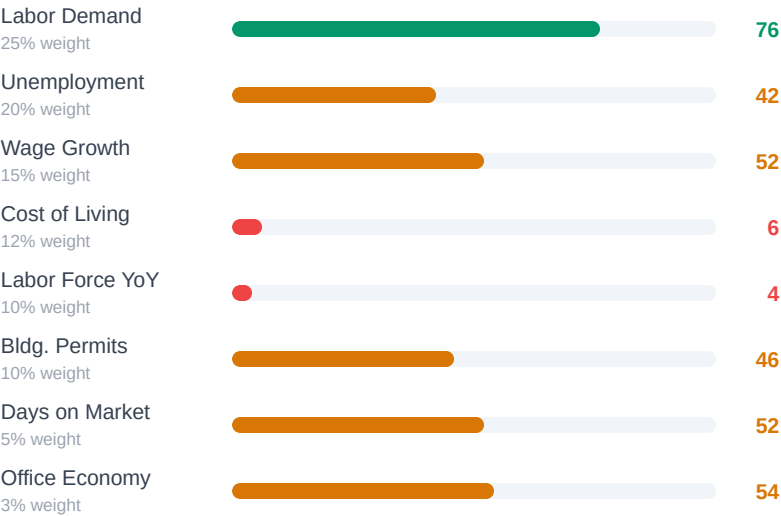
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

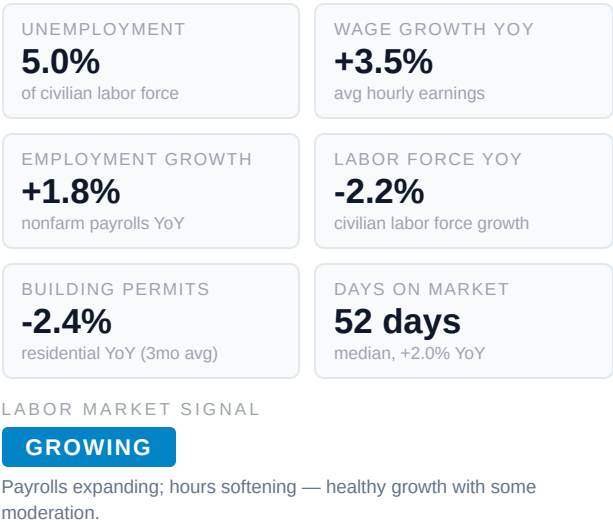
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.2th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 6.18 ranking it at the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is ranked at the 6th percentile due to a high PSF to earnings ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.61/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics provide a mixed picture of the city's economic health.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.681%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 6.18 confirms this, indicating a strong demand for labor in the city.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 5.00%, ranking it at the 42nd percentile. This indicates a near-median level of unemployment, suggesting that the market has some slack but is not overly loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that there may be some availability of workers, but wages may not be under significant downward pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.48%, ranking it at the 52nd percentile. This is a moderate level of wage growth, indicating that labor costs are rising but not excessively so. This level of wage growth also suggests that worker purchasing power is increasing, which could be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living ranked at the 6th percentile, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.61/hr is high, and the fact that PSF is falling by -1.9% year-over-year does little to alleviate the affordability concerns. This makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is contracting at a rate of -2.24% year-over-year, ranking it at the 4th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could create a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is falling by -2.43% year-over-year, ranking it at the 46th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This indicates a near-median level of market competitiveness, suggesting that workers relocating to the city may face a moderately challenging housing market. However, the rising days on market could also signal a healthy normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has an office economy ranked at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a mix of strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the affordability of the city, which could make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

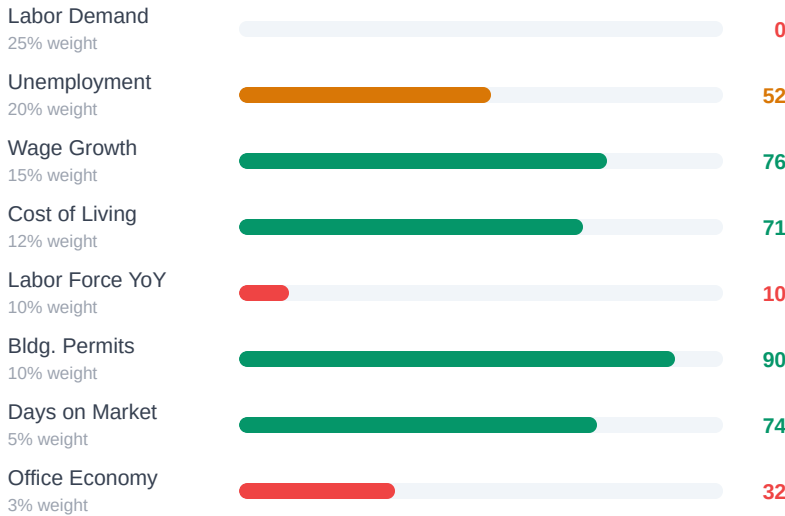
Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-2.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+53.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
39 days
median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.31% in hourly earnings. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.15% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.969% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire new talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, ranking at the 52nd percentile, which indicates a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire new employees. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.31%, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking at the 71st percentile, with a PSF of \$305/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.17/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.75. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year further supports this assessment. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction strategy for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -1.70% year-over-year, ranking at the 10th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should be prepared to compete aggressively for talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 53.15% year-over-year, ranking at the 90th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation options for the workforce in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation or expansion, as it may reduce the cost of attracting and retaining talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This ranks at the 74th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has an office economy score ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities. While the city's strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living are attractive features, the weak labor demand and shrinking labor force supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh these factors when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

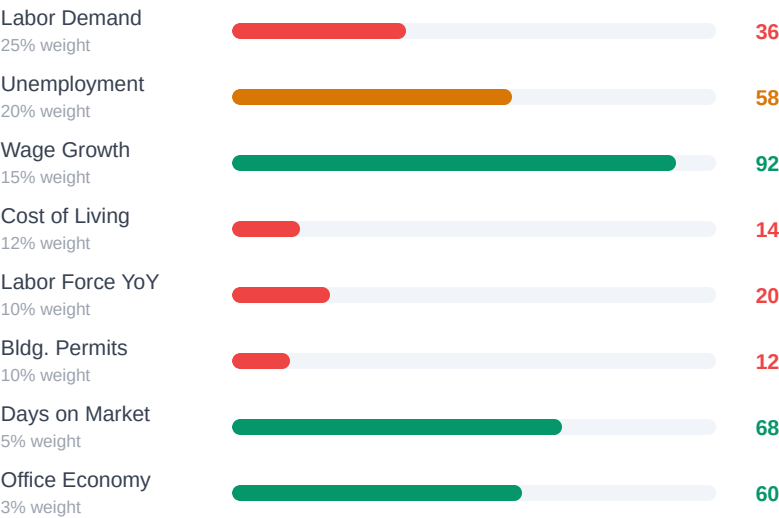
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.5th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.72%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 13.69. The combination of these two metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.482% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.53 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.40%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.72%, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which will lead to rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, workers in the city will benefit from increased purchasing power, making it an attractive location for talent.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living percentile rank of 14, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 13.69, with PSF at \$600/sqft and wages at \$43.84/hr, further reinforces this assessment. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may deter some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which will create a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when making location decisions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is -23.29%, ranking at the 12th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which may make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and businesses should consider this when making location decisions.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share of 2.92, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but the high cost of living and tightening housing supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent in this expensive city.

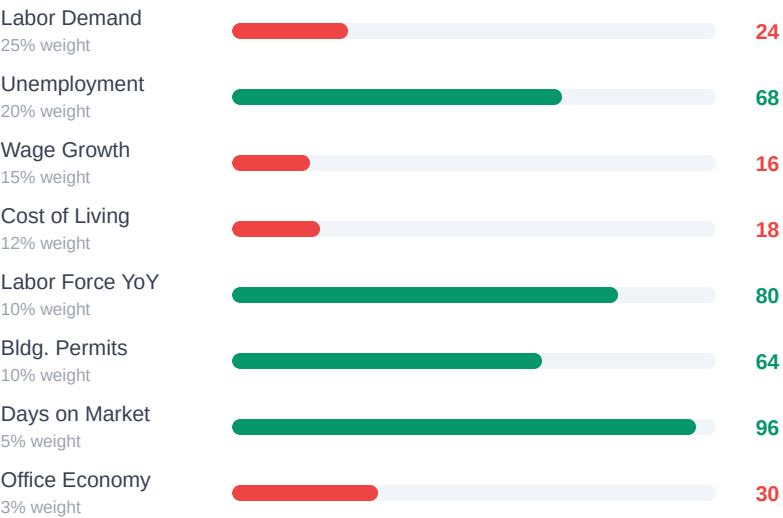
Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

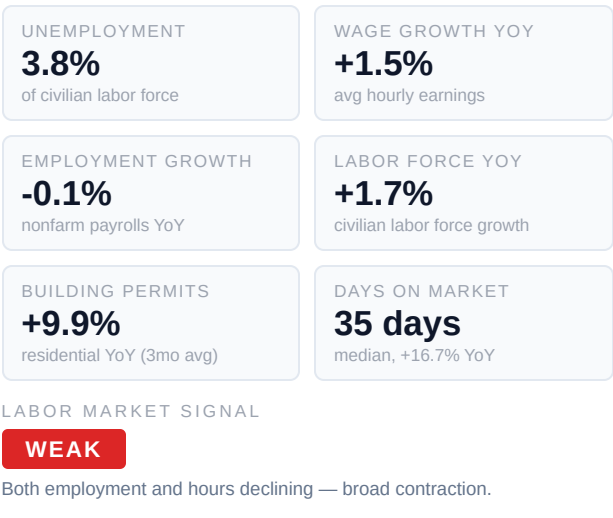
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.3th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.17, and its high unemployment rate of 3.80%, which ranks it in the 68th percentile. The labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a city with a mix of challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.09% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.171% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate and below-trend hours suggest that businesses may not be adding jobs at a pace that would drive economic growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 68th percentile. This suggests a tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.46%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the 16th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have limited bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the 18th percentile, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.30. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF and stagnant wages contribute to the city's low affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. This expanding labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier for

businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, businesses may face less competition for workers and have a larger pool of candidates to choose from.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +9.94% year-over-year, which suggests that housing supply is expanding. This growth in building permits signals that the city is likely to have a more affordable and accommodating housing market in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is currently 35 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.7%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market indicate a more competitive market for buyers, which could be beneficial for workers looking to purchase homes.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has an office economy score that ranks in the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a large number of professional or office workers, such as tech or finance companies.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a mix of challenges and opportunities, with a growing labor force and expanding housing supply. However, the city's below-average labor demand and relatively expensive cost of living may pose significant risks for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's tight labor market and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and drive up labor costs.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

43.9th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		14
Unemployment 20% weight		34
Wage Growth 15% weight		40
Cost of Living 12% weight		16
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		98
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		92
Days on Market 5% weight		98
Office Economy 3% weight		58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +67.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 46 days median, +17.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its exceptionally high labor force growth rate of +2.87% YoY. These metrics signal a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +0.27% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.951% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor demand composite score of 3.73, which falls into the bottom tier. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be facing a period of slow job growth and reduced working hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking it below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +2.89%, placing it near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power, which can contribute to local economic stability.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, with a PSF of \$474/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.45. The PSF has decreased by -1.0% YoY, which is a positive sign for affordability. However, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This significant expansion in labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can support business hiring needs and overall economic growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by +67.46% YoY, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This substantial rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +17.9%, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has an office economy percentile rank of 58th, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, which can support economic growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		10
25% weight		
Unemployment		50
20% weight		
Wage Growth		80
15% weight		
Cost of Living		41
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		22
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		96
10% weight		
Days on Market		26
5% weight		
Office Economy		26
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +106.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 39 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 43.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +5.54% ranking it in the top tier. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.68% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.075%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze, indicating that the job market is not growing. The labor demand composite score of 3.27 is in the bottom tier, confirming this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.00%, which is near the median. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this area, this means that there may be a slightly easier time finding candidates, but it also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is +5.54%, which is relatively fast. This suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to consider higher wage costs when operating in this area.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is near the median, with a percentile rank of 41. The PSF-to-earnings ratio is \$224/sqft vs \$35.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive relative to peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not have a significant advantage or disadvantage in terms of cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of -1.05% year-over-year. This means that the labor force supply is contracting, rather than expanding. As a result, businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire in this area, as the shrinking labor pool may limit their ability to find qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area has increased by +106.92% year-over-year. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering locating in this area, as it may help to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This means that the housing market is relatively stable, but still relatively fast. For workers relocating to this city, this may mean that they will face a competitive housing market, which could be a challenge.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is below average, with a percentile rank of 26. This suggests that the talent pool is not as deep as in other cities, and may not be as well-suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities for businesses. While it has high wage growth and an expanding housing supply, it also has low labor demand and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the limited labor force growth, which may limit the ability of businesses to find and hire qualified candidates.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

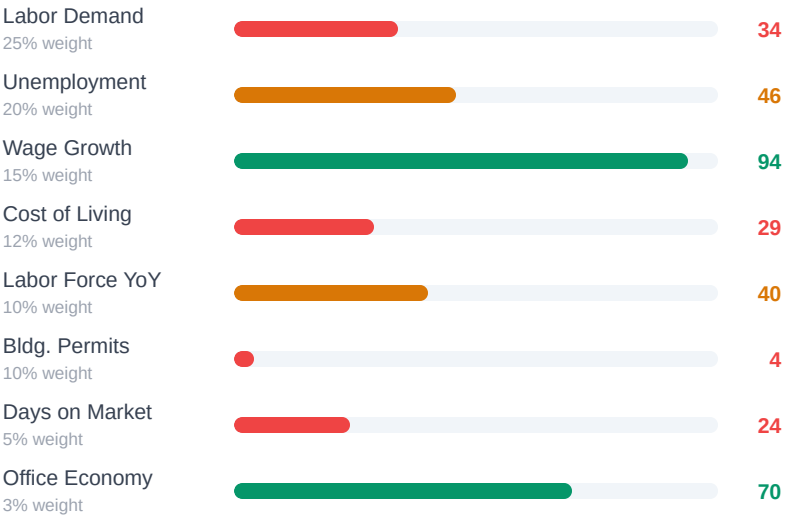
C+

POOR

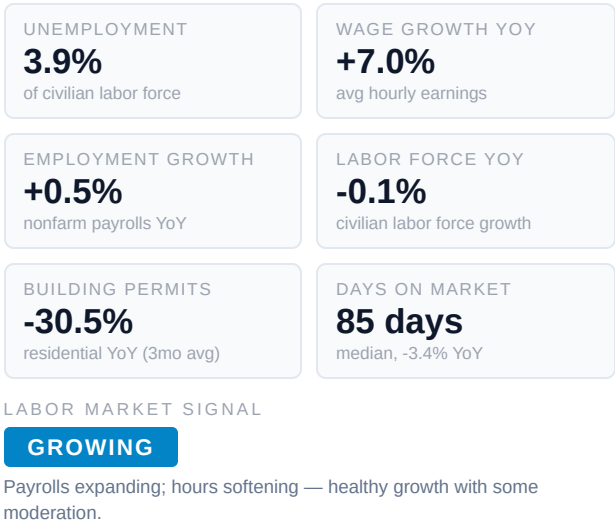
42.9th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.02%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.52, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.48% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.452% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is not sufficient to offset the decline in working hours. This scenario may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor overly loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable hiring environment, but not one with excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.02%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth indicates a strong labor market where workers have significant bargaining power, which can lead to rising labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking below average at the 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$356/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.68/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.27. The PSF has decreased by 0.8% year-over-year, slightly improving affordability. However, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has contracted by -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This slight decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has decreased by -30.46% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.4%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 24th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly. Businesses may need to provide relocation assistance or adjust their hiring timelines to accommodate the competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a professional and office worker share ranking above average at the 70th percentile, with a composite score of 3.10. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy companies. However, the city's struggling labor demand, expensive cost of living, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business.

Fresno

Fresno

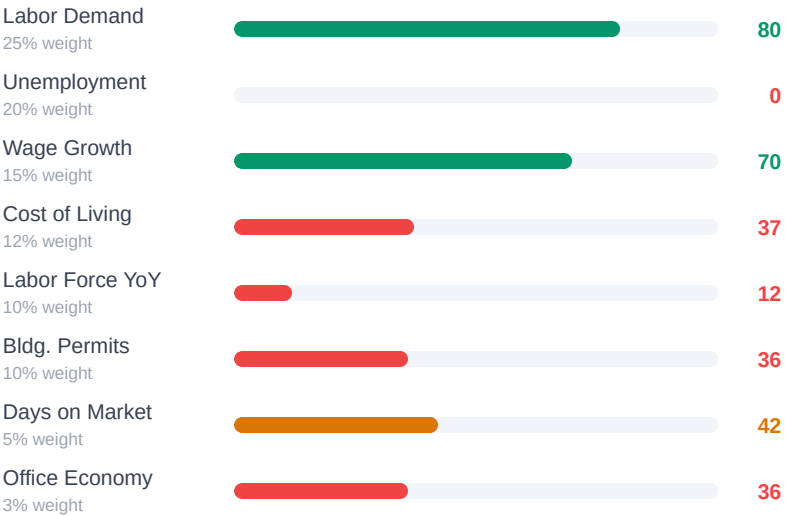
C+

POOR

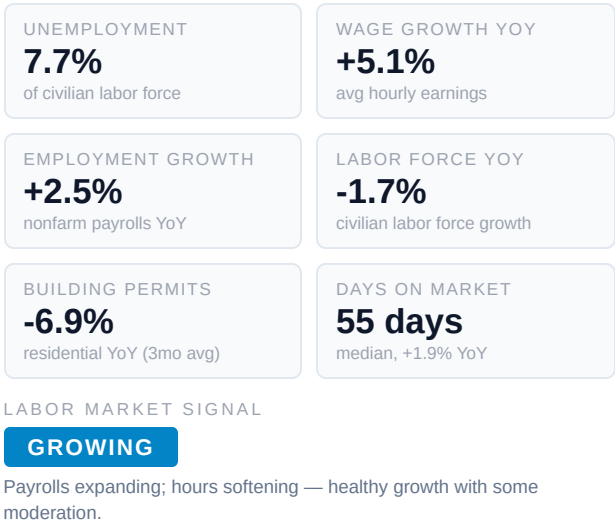
42.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 80th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 0th percentile, standing at 7.70%. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.47% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -1.481%, indicating a genuine demand expansion despite the slight decrease in hours worked. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average, with a strong labor demand composite score of 6.28. The negative hours deviation suggests some efficiency in labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is significantly higher than the national average, indicating a labor market with considerable slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Fresno may find it easier to staff their operations due to the available workforce. However, high unemployment also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could affect businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 5.14% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates good worker purchasing power. As wages grow faster than in many other cities, businesses may face increasing labor costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 37th percentile, with a price per square foot of \$263 and average hourly earnings of \$33.85, resulting in a ratio of 7.77. This indicates that Fresno is less affordable than many of its peer cities, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The static year-over-year change in PSF versus wages does not indicate any significant improvement in affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.69% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may find it challenging to fill positions due to a

dwindling pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand, potentially driving up housing costs.

Days on Market

Homes in Fresno are currently sitting on the market for a median of 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This moderate days on market figure, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile, suggests a relatively balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers. The slight increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking in the 36th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, making it more challenging for businesses in these sectors to find specialized labor. Fresno's economy is better suited for industries that are less dependent on a high concentration of professional and office workers.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a large potential workforce due to its high unemployment rate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for long-term hiring and growth strategies. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering Fresno as a location for their operations.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

42.5th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		56
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		36
Cost of Living 12% weight		0
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		82
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		34
Days on Market 5% weight		78
Office Economy 3% weight		66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.3%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.8%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.6%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +1.7%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -8.1%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +2.7% YoY 38 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.5th out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.10. The labor demand composite score of 5.37, which is near the median, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.226%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in labor demand, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, which is below average and corresponds to a percentile rank of 28th. This means that the labor market is relatively tight, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +2.76%, which is below average and ranks 36th in percentile terms. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the city are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 0th, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities in the country. With a PSF of \$367/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.34/hr, the city's high cost of living may deter some businesses from locating there, as they may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent. This could be a significant constraint for businesses considering relocation to this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, which is a top-tier performance and ranks 82nd in percentile terms. This means that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and grow in the city. The increasing labor force can provide a larger pool of potential employees for businesses to tap into.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has decreased by -8.13% year-over-year, which is below average and ranks 34th in percentile terms. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. This may be a concern for businesses that require a steady influx of new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%. This corresponds to a percentile rank of 78th, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be a positive factor in their decision to move.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 66th, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and a growing labor force, which can provide a talented and dedicated workforce. However, the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant risks that businesses should factor into their decision-making process, as they may need to offer wage premiums and contend with affordability issues to attract and retain top talent.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

POOR

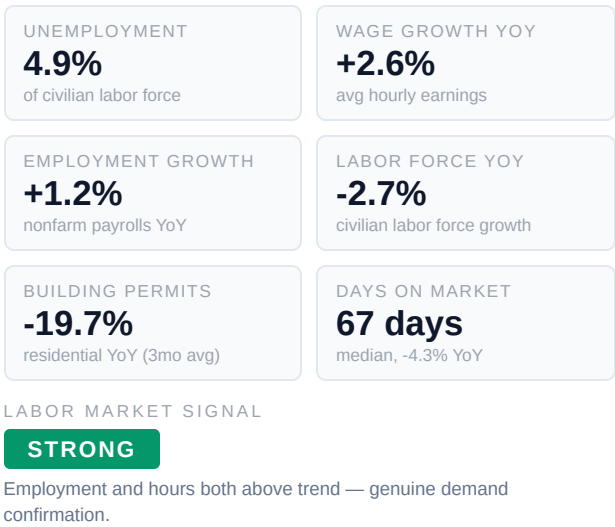
42.0th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42nd out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 82nd percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth but also significant competition for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +1.23% year-over-year, combined with a +0.313% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing real job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are actively hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler stands at 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate implies that there is significant competition for labor, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may be challenging to find available workers without offering competitive salaries.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +2.61%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the relatively slow wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the low unemployment rate and the resulting competition for labor.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$267/sqft to \$37.56/hr, ranking near the median at the 55th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is neither extremely affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is falling by -1.5% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively manageable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has decreased by -19.67% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As the labor market remains tight, this reduction in housing supply could exacerbate the competition for labor.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 67 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market might indicate a minor normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the top tier at the 84th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but might be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented requirements.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment with genuine job growth, but it also presents significant challenges, particularly in terms of labor supply and housing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which could limit the city's ability to support long-term business expansion and growth.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C+

POOR

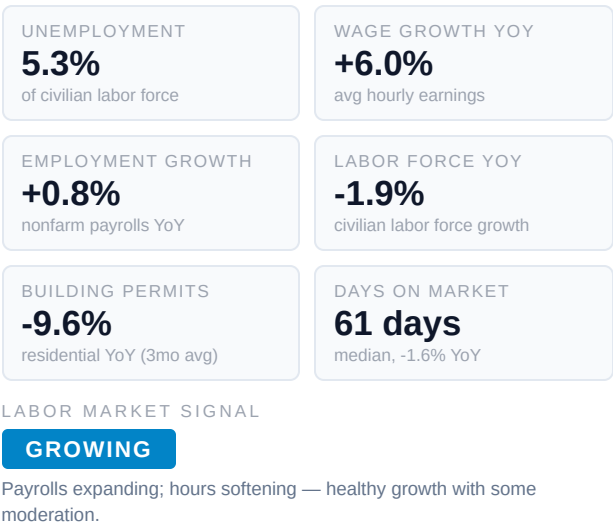
39.2th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.02%, and its struggling labor demand, with employment growth of only 0.79% and weekly hours 0.845% below trend. These metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends but also significant challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.79% is modest, and when combined with weekly hours 0.845% below trend, it signals a labor demand environment that is not expanding genuinely. This suggests that while some jobs are being added, the overall labor market is not experiencing significant growth, and hours are not increasing as they would in a strong demand environment. This combination may indicate a degree of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.30% indicates a labor market with some slack, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This means that businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire in this market, as there are more potential candidates available. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.02%, this city is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers but will also increase worker purchasing power, potentially benefiting local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this city, with a PSF of \$333/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.60, resulting in a ratio of 9.35, is below average in terms of affordability, ranking at the 35th percentile. This means the city is not particularly affordable relative to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -9.60%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This sharp decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze ahead, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for the workforce to find accommodation, ultimately affecting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 61 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This relatively fast market, with homes selling quickly, could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially impacting a business's ability to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 0th percentile, this city has a very shallow professional talent pool. This makes it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that rely on deep knowledge-economy talent pools, but it may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a mixed bag, with strong wage growth being a significant positive, but it also presents challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the combination of a less affordable cost of living and a shrinking labor pool, which could hinder a business's growth and operational capacity.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

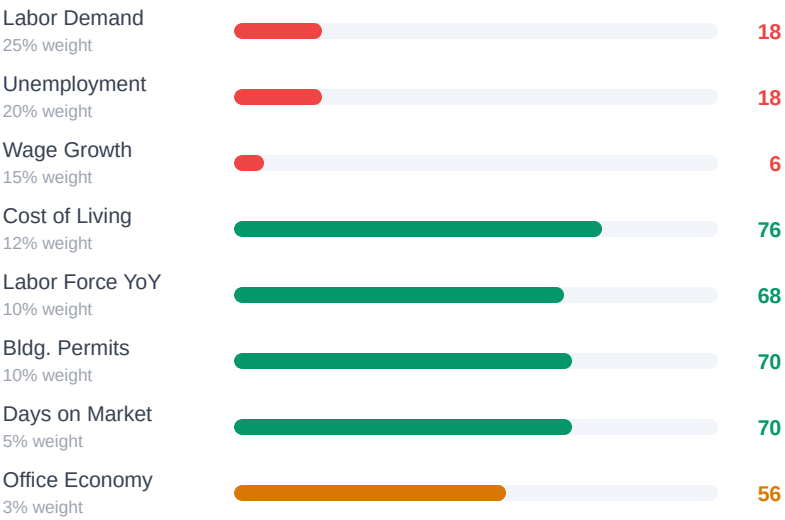
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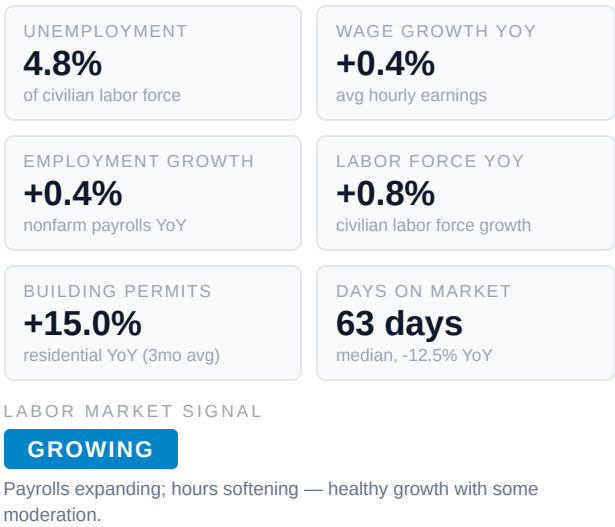
37.0th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville has an overall grade of C, ranking 37th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score that reflects its mixed economic performance. The city's labor demand and wage growth metrics, at 18th and 6th percentiles respectively, most define its current economic character, with employment growth at +0.36% and weekly hours deviation at -0.794%. These numbers signal a weak labor market with potential survivor squeeze, where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is +0.36%, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.794%, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.01 is in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile. This indicates a relatively slack labor market, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. With this level of unemployment, businesses may face less wage pressure compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is +0.39% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power may not be increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score that ranks at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of \$216/sqft, which is decreasing by -3.1% year-over-year, relative to average hourly earnings of \$36.85. This makes the city more affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of +0.78% year-over-year, which is above average, at the 68th percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies a positive trend for hiring capacity, as more workers are available to fill job openings. This growth could support business expansion and relocation decisions.

Building Permits

Building permits in Jacksonville are increasing by +15.03% year-over-year, which is above average, at the 70th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. As housing supply increases, it may alleviate some of the pressure on the local real estate market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.5%, which ranks at the 70th percentile. This relatively fast market means homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing trend may indicate a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share is at the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, but it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that demand a deeper talent pool. The city's economy is more diverse, with a mix of industries beyond just office sectors.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers a mixed bag for businesses, with a relatively affordable cost of living and expanding labor force, but also a weak labor market and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited depth of professional talent, which may impact the ability to attract and retain specialized workers, particularly in knowledge-intensive industries.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

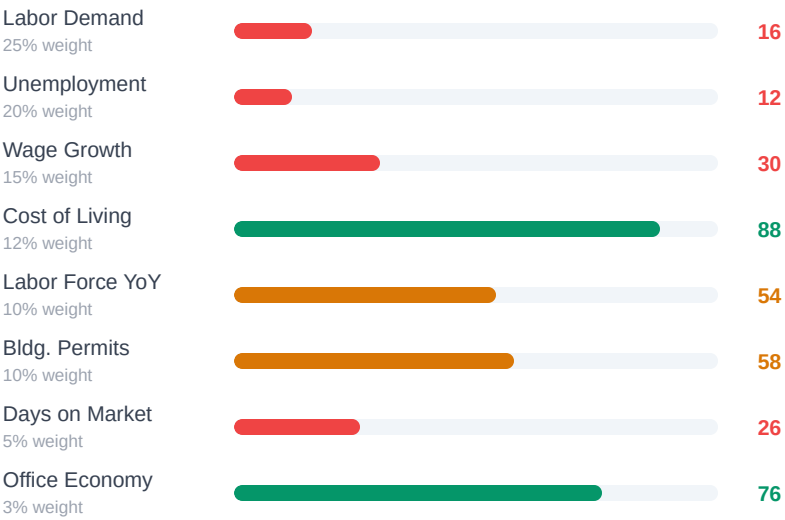
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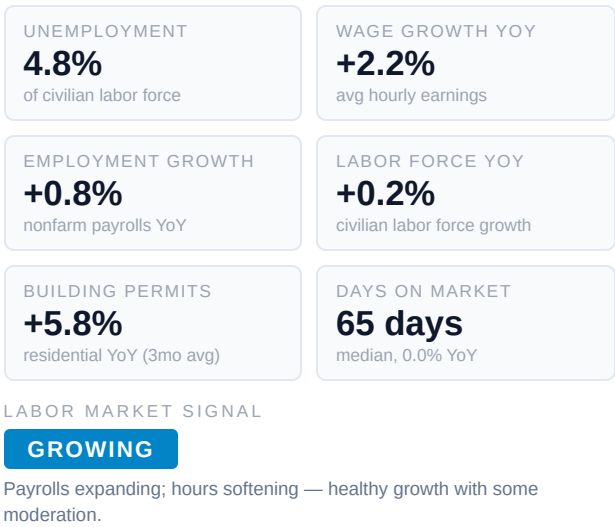
36.2th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and high cost of living affordability. The city's labor demand composite score of 3.99 and unemployment rate of 4.80% are key metrics defining its current economic character, with the latter indicating a relatively loose labor market. Specifically, the labor demand is characterized by employment growth of +0.85% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -1.731% from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.85% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -1.731% from its own trend signal a contraction in labor demand, as hours are running below trend despite job growth. This combination suggests that the job market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.99, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being tight. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it relatively easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate's percentile rank of 12th highlights the challenges of a loose labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.20% is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not rapidly. The wage growth rate suggests a relatively flat cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and earnings of \$32.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.30, is relatively affordable, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. The fact that PSF is falling by -4.4% YoY further enhances affordability. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can be drawn without needing significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.23% YoY, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity in the city is not constrained by a shrinking labor pool, providing a slight advantage for businesses looking to expand.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +5.83%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits signals that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which should help maintain or improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 65 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, indicating a stable market. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, providing a relatively balanced environment for those looking to move.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 3.22, ranks above average at the 76th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles but may be less ideal for those dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a growing labor force, albeit with moderate wage growth and a loose labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand, which may signal underlying economic challenges that could impact business expansion and growth prospects.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

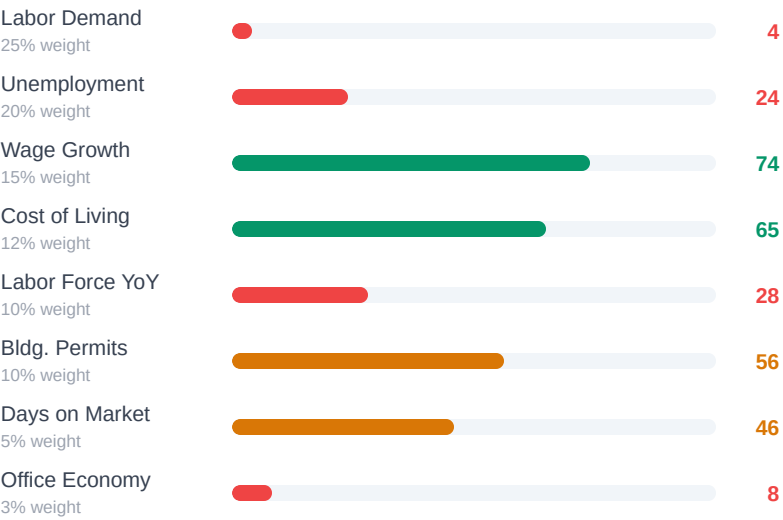
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VERY POOR

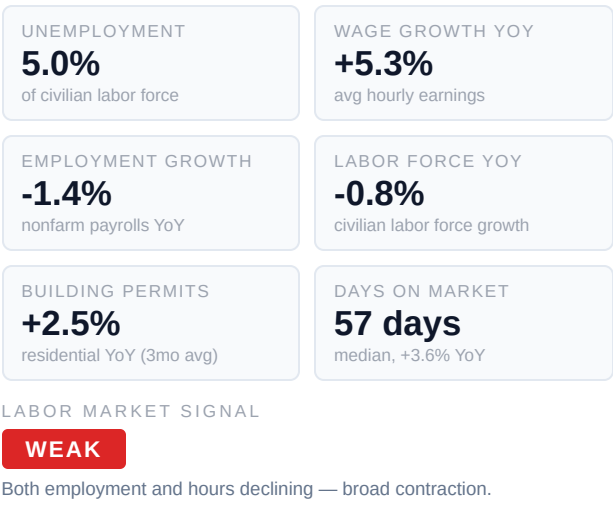
35.7th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and low office economy share. The labor demand composite score of 2.28, combining a -1.44% employment growth rate and a -0.393% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a low share of professional and office workers, characterizes the city's current economic challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -1.44% and weekly hours deviation of -0.393% from the city's own trend indicate a labor market that is contracting, with fewer jobs being added and hours worked below the trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the labor market is experiencing a contraction rather than a growth phase. The low labor demand composite score of 2.28 further emphasizes this point, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.00% places the city below the average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it does have some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may still face challenges in finding the right talent, albeit with less wage pressure than in tighter markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.27% is above average, ranking at the 74th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising faster than in most other cities, which can lead to higher labor costs for employers. On the other hand, it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$306/sqft to \$42.18/hr, and a PSF that is falling by -2.2% YoY, the city ranks above average in terms of affordability, at the 65th percentile. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, which can be a significant advantage for talent attraction without needing to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.81% year-over-year, indicating that the labor force supply is contracting. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.48%, which is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile. This slight increase suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. However, the pace of this expansion is moderate, and thus, its impact on future affordability and workforce accommodation will be gradual.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This indicates a market that is slowing down, becoming more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The near-median ranking at the 46th percentile suggests that while homes are not selling as quickly as in hotter markets, the market is not excessively slow, providing a relatively balanced environment for both buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.68, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that rely heavily on tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations. Instead, the city's economy may be more conducive to industries that are less dependent on a deep professional and office worker base.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a business environment with above-average wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, which can be attractive for talent acquisition and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which can pose significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

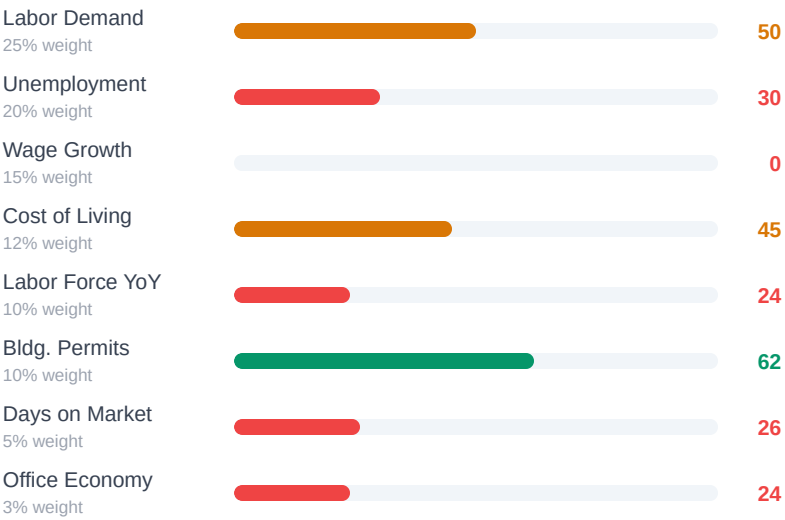
C

VERY POOR

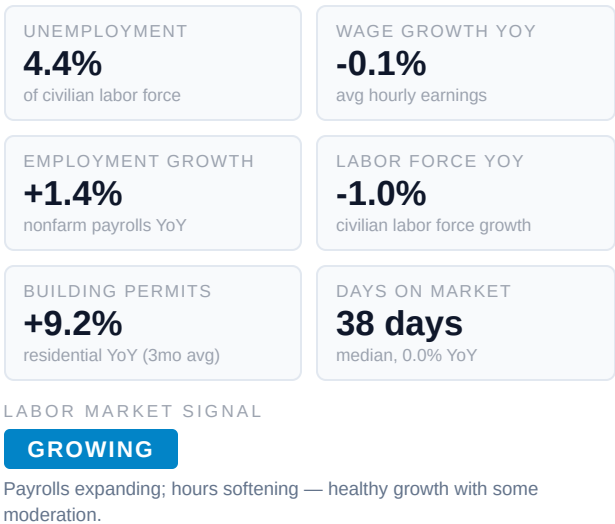
34.5th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.31, near the median, and an unemployment rate of 4.40%, below average, define its current economic character. Specifically, the employment growth rate of +1.36% and weekly hours deviation of -0.894% signal a mixed labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.36% and weekly hours deviation of -0.894% indicate a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, suggesting some degree of survivor squeeze. This combination signals that while the city is adding jobs, the existing workforce is not seeing a significant increase in hours worked, which may impact productivity. The labor demand composite score of 5.31, near the median, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.14% is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant wage inflation, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$208/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.22/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.17, is near the median, ranking in the 45th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.9% YoY further supports the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +9.15%, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which can lead to better affordability and accommodation for the workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year direction of +0.0%, indicating a relatively stable and accessible market for homebuyers. This means that workers relocating to this city may find it relatively easy to find and purchase a home, which can be a significant advantage for businesses trying to attract talent. However, the below-average percentile rank of 26th suggests that the market may still be somewhat competitive.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 1.80, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. On the other hand, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on specialized office workers.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, which can be attractive for talent acquisition and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to invest in workforce development or attraction strategies to remain competitive.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

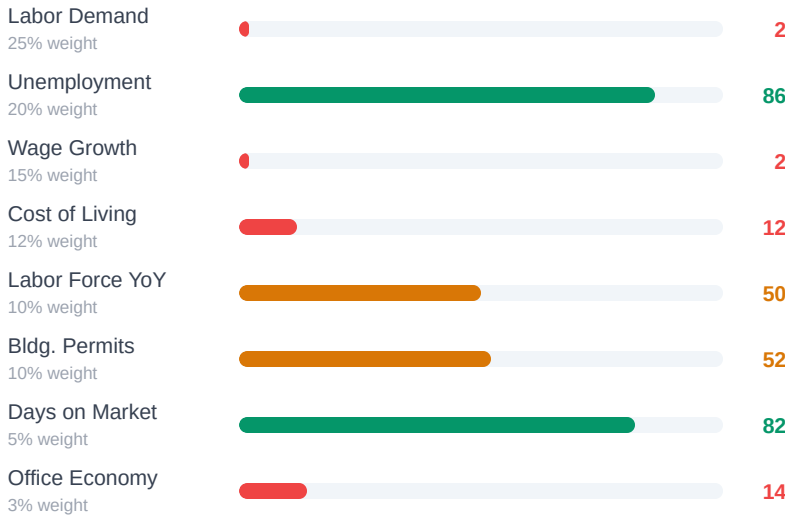
C

VERY POOR

34.2th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

47 days

median, +4.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 2.22, combining a -1.17% employment growth rate and a +0.446% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with the low wage growth rate, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -1.17% and weekly hours deviation of +0.446% indicate a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that while hours are slightly above trend, the overall job market is shrinking. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The low labor demand composite score of 2.22 reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.40% ranks in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. The tight market implies that hiring may be more challenging and expensive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.09% is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.96, based on \$166/sqft and \$33.45/hr, and a percentile rank of 12th, the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is increasing by 4.4% YoY, further reducing affordability. This means that the city has a disadvantage in attracting talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This modest growth indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity. However, the growth rate is not strong enough to significantly alleviate labor market tightness.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -0.22%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This slight decline in permits suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability concerns and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.4%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the market is more accessible, with less competition for housing.

Office Economy

The office economy percentile rank of 14th indicates a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a business a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but also stagnant wage growth and a high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential for significant wage pressure and competition for talent, which may offset any benefits of locating in this city.

Richmond

Richmond

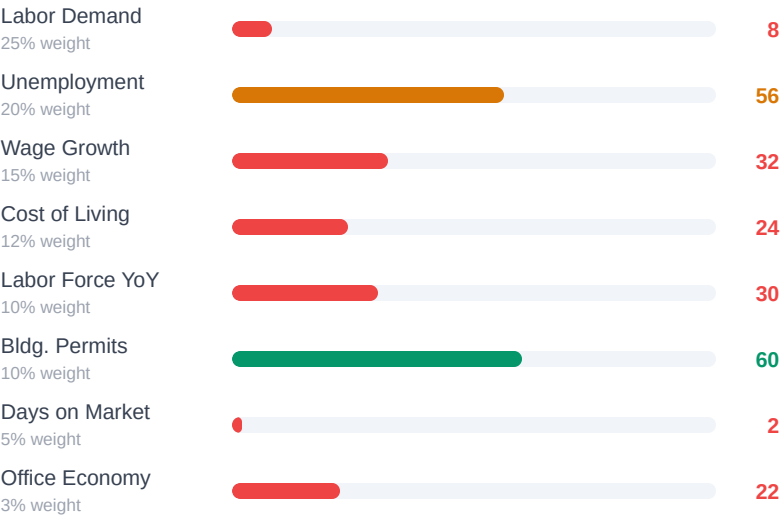
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CRITICAL

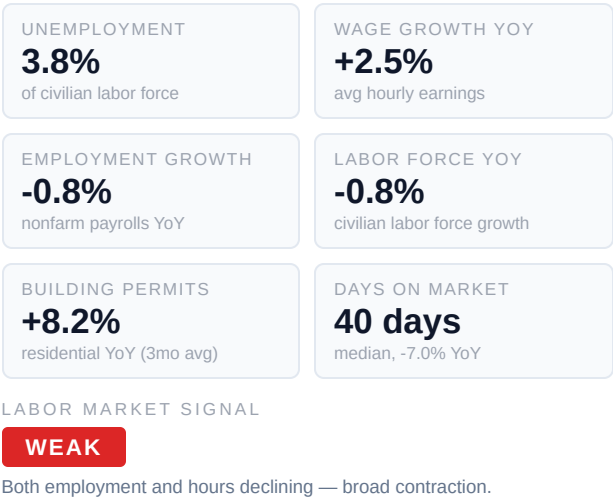
30.7th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.24, and its low office economy share, ranking 22nd percentile. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -0.76% and weekly hours deviation of -0.415% are key metrics that shape the city's current economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.76%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.415% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with payrolls contracting and hours below trend. The scenario suggests that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and working hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, ranking 56th percentile, which indicates a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire in Richmond is that it may still face some competition for talent, but not as intense as in cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.49%, ranking 32nd percentile, which is below average. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not as quickly as in other cities. For workers, this means that their purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$229/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The implication for talent attraction is that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the higher cost of living, making it less competitive in attracting talent without additional incentives.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is growing at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This decline suggests that the city's workforce is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond has increased by +8.22% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -7.0%. This rapid sales pace indicates a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. The low days on market suggests that the city's housing market is hot, and businesses may need to consider this when relocating employees or planning for workforce expansion.

Office Economy

Richmond's office economy share ranks 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Richmond metro area offers a business a relatively affordable housing supply expansion, but its weak labor demand, low office economy share, and shrinking labor force pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited talent pool and declining labor force, which could hinder business growth and expansion plans.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

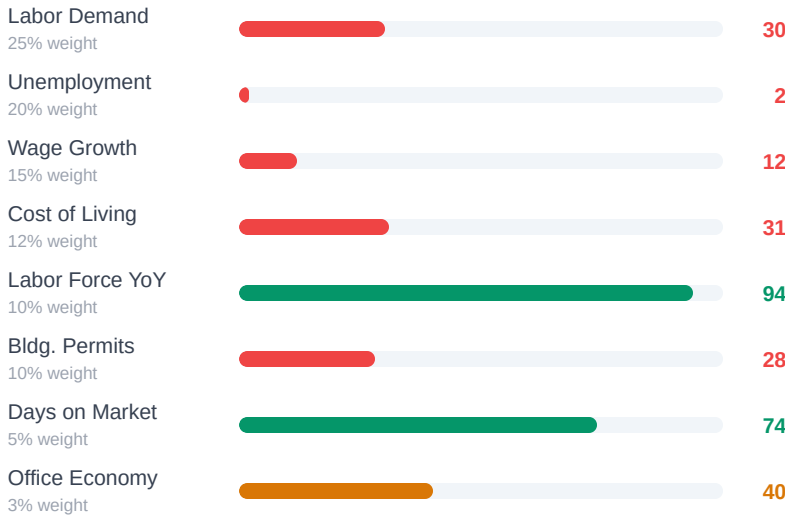
C-

CRITICAL

30.5th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+2.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days
median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.40% and its sluggish labor demand composite score of 4.43, which ranks in the 30th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is a modest +0.16% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running -0.098% below trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing despite some job growth, which may indicate a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.40%, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with significant slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the low unemployment rate means it will be harder to find available workers, leading to potential wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +0.60%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it in the 31st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$186/sqft to \$36.68/hr, or 5.07. This indicates the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The modest affordability, as signaled by the low percentile rank, may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.68% year-over-year, ranking in the 94th percentile. This significant expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -10.99% year-over-year, ranking in the 28th percentile. This decline in residential building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn are currently sitting on the market for a median of 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.6%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This slower market, as indicated by the high percentile rank for days on market, means that workers relocating to this city may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks in the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but it may not be ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance hubs.

In conclusion, Detroit-Warren-Dearborn offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and modestly expensive cost of living, alongside a rapidly growing labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges due to the decline in building permits and tightening housing supply.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C-

CRITICAL

29.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		28
Unemployment 20% weight		48
Wage Growth 15% weight		14
Cost of Living 12% weight		10
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		16
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		74
Days on Market 5% weight		6
Office Economy 3% weight		10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.4% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +16.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 46 days median, -6.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.32, and its stagnant wage growth, at +1.05% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.34% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.457% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of slow growth or even a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some wage pressure, particularly if they are looking to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.05%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, with a PSF of \$344/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.15/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.02. This means that the city is relatively expensive, requiring wage premiums to attract talent. The fact that PSF is rising +0.3% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is increasing by +16.17% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 46 days, with a year-over-year decline of -6.1%. This rapid pace of home sales signals a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The low percentile rank of 6th percentile further emphasizes the competitive nature of the market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.72, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor environment, but it also presents significant challenges, including a contracting labor force and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the availability of skilled talent and make it challenging to attract and retain top performers.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

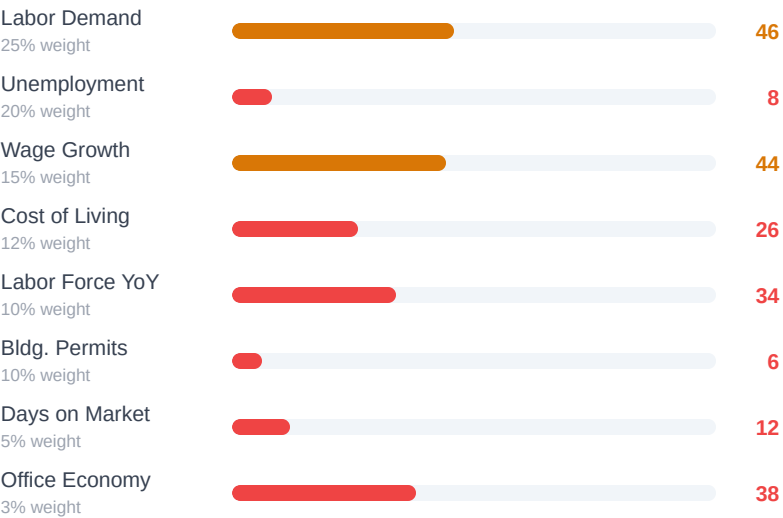
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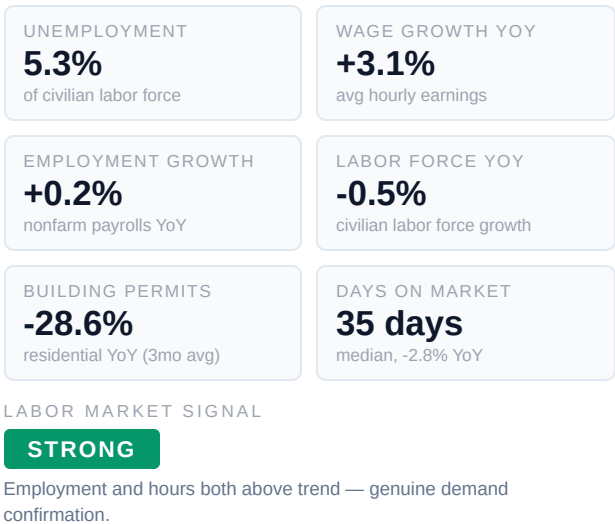
28.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.30% and its stagnant labor force growth, with a year-over-year change of -0.53%. These metrics signal a challenging labor market with limited expansion opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.17% year-over-year, combined with a +0.674% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. However, the labor demand composite score of 5.21 is near the median, indicating a moderate level of job market activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.30%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.11%, ranking it near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power, which could benefit businesses that rely on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$37.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.92. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 2.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -0.53% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions. The implication is that businesses may need to invest more in recruitment and training to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by 28.57% year-over-year. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. This, in turn, could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.8%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the fact that days on market are decreasing suggests that the market is still competitive, and businesses may need to offer relocation assistance to attract talent.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has an office economy score that ranks it in the 38th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.22. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a labor market with some slack, making it easier to hire workers, but also poses challenges in terms of labor force growth and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the relatively high cost of living and tightening housing supply.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

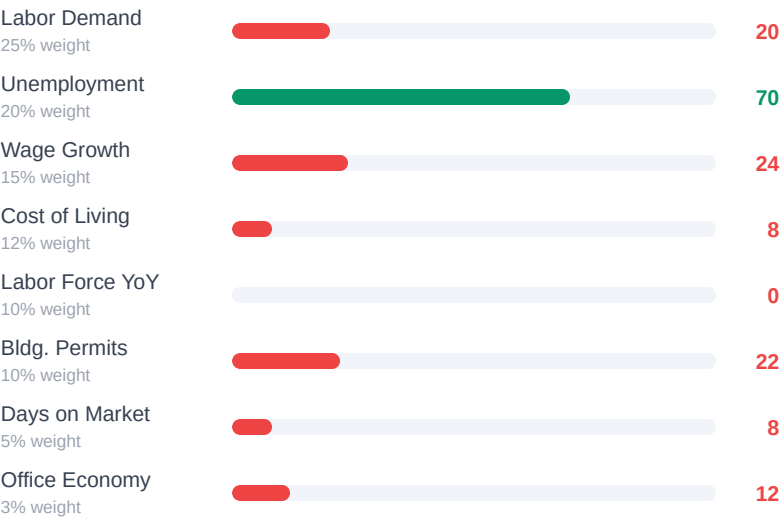
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CRITICAL

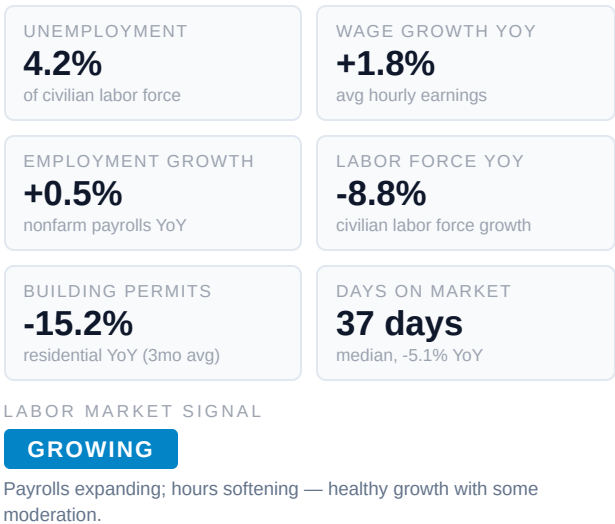
26.5th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 26.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 4.11, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.20%, which actually indicates a relatively tight labor market, ranking it in the 70th percentile. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment with both positive and negative signals.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +0.47% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.851% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is accompanied by a decrease in working hours, indicating that the existing workforce is not being fully utilized. This suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, which ranks in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees, and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer higher salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +1.83%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also means that employers may need to budget for increasing labor costs over time.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the 8th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$221/sqft to \$32.56/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.79. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the PSF is rising 4.2% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is shrinking at a rate of -8.76% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is dwindling. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their hiring strategies in this market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is decreasing by -15.25% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is currently 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options. The low percentile rank of 8th percentile for days on market further underscores the competitive nature of the housing market.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood ranks in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, and may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood offers a mixed economic environment with both positive and negative signals, posing challenges for businesses looking to locate or expand in the area. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and expansion.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

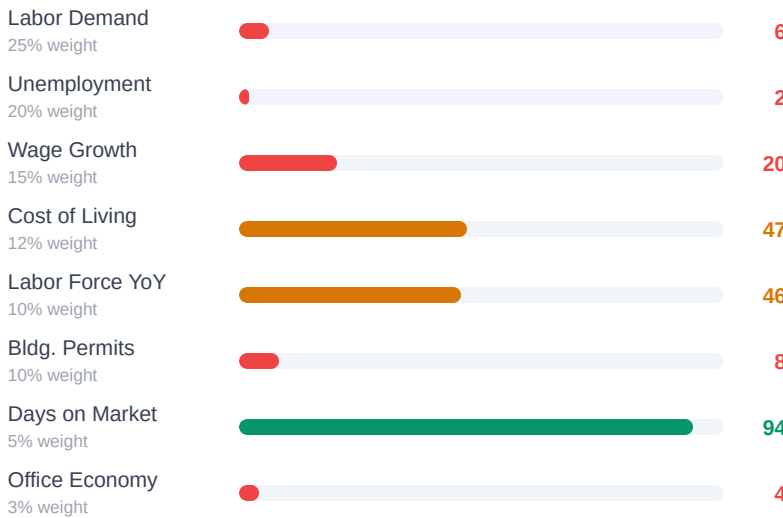
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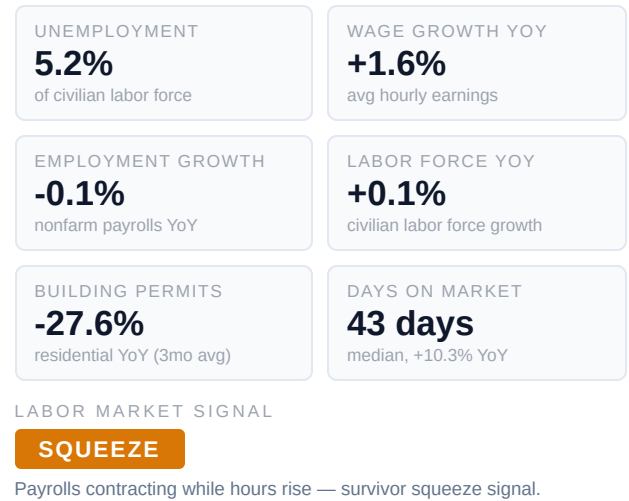
20.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 20.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.99. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.07% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 5.20%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.07% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.215%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 2.99, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. This indicates a relatively loose labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.61%, ranking below average at 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in the area will experience some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be sufficient to drive significant economic growth.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living ratio of \$178/sqft to \$31.29/hr, with a percentile rank of 47th. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, with a relatively stable cost of living. The city's affordability may attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, but it is not a major differentiator.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.08% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 46th percentile. This slow growth rate suggests that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a limited pace. Businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the growth rate is not a major constraint.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -27.55% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 8th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could negatively impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%, ranking in the top tier at 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests a less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.38, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively loose labor market and moderate wage growth, but its low labor demand and declining housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the city's limited ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce, which may constrain business growth and expansion plans.